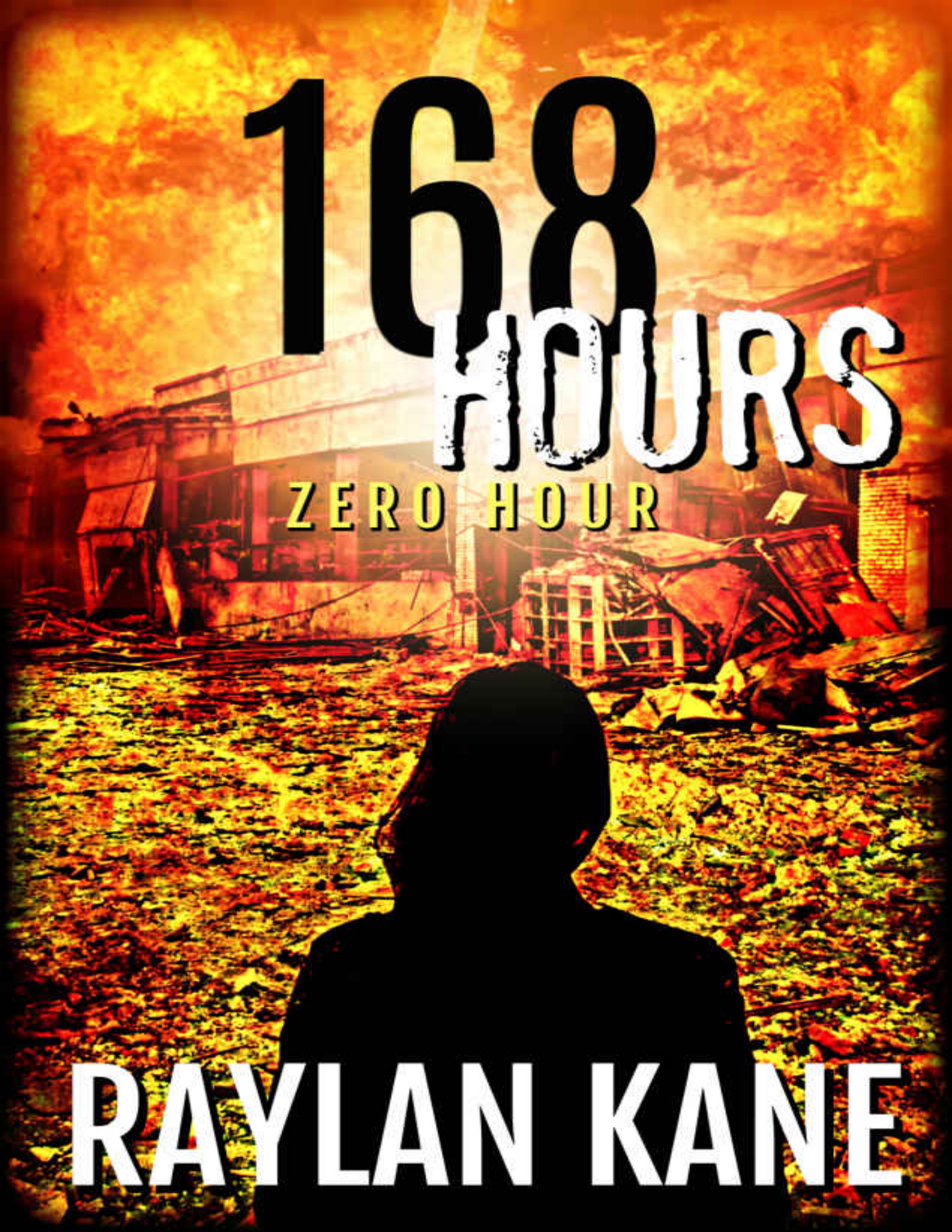




168 HOURS

ZERO HOUR

RAYLAN KANE

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For Melissa,

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1.

-ONE HOUR BEFORE-

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NESTOR SINGH

ABOARD *TALCAHUANO* RESEARCH VESSEL
DRAKE PASSAGE, 300 km SOUTH OF CAPE HORN
12:05 PM LOCAL TIME

Perhaps the lack of whales should have been a sign. Nestor Singh studied the readouts from the hydrophones and frowned with frustration. Not one reading from a humpback had been recorded from the time they left Puerto Montt. Not one dolphin cry, no porpoises, no seals. Come to think of it, neither he nor the crew noted the presence of any bird species known to frequent Drake Passage. Michelle Campos, Nestor's research assistant from the university sidled up along side him, sensing his frustration.

"Still nothing?" She said.

Nestor stood with arms folded, glaring down at the screen. "No."

"Jorge's got lunch ready downstairs," Michelle said, "stew, I think."

"I'm not hungry," Nestor said, planting his palms on the counter top, hovering over the screen, willing something to happen. "You go ahead though."

"It's like every living creature suddenly became allergic to the Cape," Michelle said, half-joking. "I've never seen anything like it."

"Yeah."

"Should I be worried?"

"About the grant?" Nestor said. "We don't find any whales, we might have bigger things to worry about."

"We still have two more days. Something's gotta turn up. It's not like the entire ocean's taken a vacation, right?"

"Everything I'm seeing says different. It's as though everything breathing's up and vanished. Except us."

Michelle looked at her boss carefully, noting the lines creasing the sides of his eyes. She stepped away from him and walked toward the stairs. "If you're trying to frighten me, Nestor, it's working."

"Yes, well, it's these readouts that scare me."

PRINCE HENRY OF SUSSEX

WATTA VILLAS RESORT

SRI LANKA

9:35 PM LOCAL TIME

The young prince, already half-drunk on vodka, accepted a bump of coke off the back of Clarissa Clark's hand.

"Happy Birthday, Henry," she said with a wry smile. He snuffed up the powder and she popped her hand to her mouth. "Oh," she gasped, "I forgot to call you Your Highness." She leaned away from him, her tiny frame pushing into the oversized cushion at the end of the sofa.

"I suppose you could rightfully call me that," Henry said, smiling. "I am definitely high right now."

They shared a laugh and the newly 22-year old pulled on Clarissa's sleeve removing her loose button-up shirt completely. She sat there, topless, feigning shyness for a moment, but then stood up, motioning to the pool in front of them extending from inside the room out into the calm evening air. A purple sunset in the distance beyond.

"Shall we go for a swim?" She said, joyfully planting her hands on her hips.

"A frightful idea in my condition, I'm afraid," Henry said. "I had something else in mind." He pointed to the massive bed directly behind the sofa.

"I see," Clarissa mocked. "So, that's how you thought the night was going to go."

"Indeed. Have I misjudged?"

"Hardly."

Clarissa stepped across the clay tile and planted each knee onto the sofa, straddling the prince. He reached up and caressed the tanned skin on her back and she draped her long brown locks into his face. She untied her white bikini bottoms and tossed them behind her to the floor. Henry kicked his trousers off and she lowered herself to him.

"This is more what you had in mind, huh?" She murmured in his ear.

His head, swimming in the alcohol and cocaine, felt light and for a moment he couldn't speak. He felt her warmth against him and the room

began to spin around faster and faster. Henry could feel her breathing become more rapid as she bit into his neck.

They both nearly jumped out of their skin when a loud pounding sounded at the door.

“Oh my God!” Henry exclaimed, pushing for Clarissa to move off of him. She fell onto the sofa beside him, overcome with giggles. “What is it?” He shouted at the door. Clarissa laughed, mocking his sudden seriousness, his attempt at appearing sober.

“Your Highness,” came a muffled voice through the door, “there's a call for you.”

Henry sighed. He stood up and wrapped himself in a terrycloth robe. He marched to the door and flung it open to see his personal assistant standing there in his suit, a pained expression on his face.

“Terence, it's bloody well ten o'clock at night. What do you want?”

Terence held a cell phone out to the young prince. “It's about your father, Highness. That's your aunt on the phone.”

Henry frowned with confusion. “What's his trouble with me now?”

He took the phone to his ear and tried his best to shake off his stupor. For two minutes he stood there, phone to his ear. He spoke very little, his aunt did most of the talking. After hanging up, he handed the phone back to Terence, his eyes turned to glass.

Suddenly, the world became heavier and larger than it'd ever seemed to him before. Henry wasn't sure what to do. The news hit him hard. His father, the King of England, dead of a heart attack. All so sudden and tragic. It happened on the golf course. It didn't seem real. He was the King's only son, his only heir. Everything was about to change.

Terence looked at the young man with a mixture of sadness and worry. “What would you like to do, Highness?”

Henry stared past him, as though in a trance. “I need to be alone,” Henry said. “For now.”

“Of course,” Terence nodded. “I'll be back to check in on you in a bit. We need to put together a statement. We'll arrange a flight as well. Perhaps in the morning.”

“Fine.”

His assistant walked away, Henry closed the door. He walked back to the sofa and plunked himself down.

“What is it?” Clarissa asked, sliding toward him, twisting a lock of his blond hair in her finger. “Is everything alright?”

“It's my father,” Henry said, still in disbelief. “He's dead.”

Clarissa, not really knowing the young prince on a personal level before this night, believed what she read in the press that Henry and his father were never close. She smiled slightly and turned his chin toward her with two fingers. “And now you are King,” she said. “Your Highness, indeed.” She slid her hands toward his crotch.

Henry frowned at the girl. He pushed her hand away and leaned in the opposite direction. “Please leave,” he said to her. “I wish to be alone.”

“I'm sorry,” Clarissa caught herself, “I thought you and your father-”

“Just go!”

Upset by the sternness of his rebuke, she rushed to find her clothes. With tears in her eyes, she quickly dressed, grabbed her purse and ran out.

LAUREN SIMMS & JEFF GREENING

TREELINE ROAD
VINELAND, ONTARIO
12:05 PM LOCAL TIME

Dan Resey, Jeff Greening's best man, navigated the black Yukon full of groomsmen and Jeff himself, around a bend in the road. He drove along a rural highway that cut through a forest of oak, maple, and beech. A black Jeep Cherokee was directly ahead of him as they coasted to a stop sign. Dan could see the Jeep was also making a right turn.

"You do realize you're tailgating?" Alistair, Jeff's personal assistant on his House & Home Network show, Flip Hunters, spoke up from the back. Jeff nodded in agreement.

"Yeah, man," a drunk groomsman named Chris piped up from the third row of seats all the way back, "should've let me drive."

Dan turned right staying close behind the Jeep.

Jeff turned and looked at the others behind him and pointed at Chris. "Jesus, how many did he have out there?" Jeff said, "we only played nine holes."

"Yeah," his buddy Matt said, "and I think he had a drink on each one."

"That's right, bro," Chris added. "Best game of my life."

"Dude, you shot like 10 over," Dan replied, glancing at him in the mirror.

"I blame the beer cart girl," Matt said. "I feel a bit buzzed too. She kept coming around and around."

"And you just had to, right?" Alistair said.

"Hey, brother, Jeff only gets married once."

"Or so he hopes," Dan said, laughing. He turned his attention back to the road. "Why the hell is this Jeep driving so slow?" He noticed the Jeep's right indicator light flicked on same time as he engaged his.

"Oh, looks like they're coming to your wedding, buddy," Matt said.

"They're a bit early," Jeff said.

"Dude," Matt said, "you're getting married in like, less than hour. If anything we're late."

"Nah, we're fine."

Dan drove onto the Maplevue Lake Conservation Area, passed through a gate being held open for wedding guests, and parked on the gravel lot a

few spots down from where the Cherokee had parked. As soon as the Yukon came to a stop a group of well-dressed people descended from a gray stone building led by Jeff's mother, Candice. She lifted the bottom of her dress as she tromped across the grass, clutching a bouquet of wildflowers, a scowl on her face.

"Uh, oh dude," Matt pointed to her, "somebody's in trouble."

"We all are," Dan said.

They all exited the vehicle, the groomsmen abandoning Jeff to escape Candice's wrath. Jeff looked at them slinking away and laughed. "Cowards," he said.

Candice marched up to him, unimpressed. "It's not good that you're just getting here now, you do realize?" She said.

"Mother, it's fine," Jeff said, "look we're here, we're dressed. We're ready to go."

"Lauren's been here for an hour already, Jeffery. She'd have been worried if she knew you weren't here yet, but she's been upstairs with the girls, I don't think she knows you were almost late to your own wedding."

"Where's she at?" Jeff said trying to lighten things up, "let's go take a peak."

"Very funny," Candice said, quickly realizing there was no use in being angry with her son on his wedding day. "You had me worried."

"And now I'm here. Everything's good." He smiled at her and for a moment she saw him again as that mischievous little kid she used to chase around the yard. Whatever frustration she felt melted away in a heartbeat.

"Yes," she said, a bit of longing in her voice, a flicker of nostalgia, "you're right. Now you're here." He offered his arm to her and she took a deep breath and curled her arm under his. Then they walked back across the grass towards the stone building. "C'mon," she said to him, a tear forming in corner of her eye, "time to get you married."

THE TRAVERS FAMILY

MOUNTED PLACE, MONTANA

10:05 AM LOCAL TIME

Georgia Travers parked her '72 Ford Bronco in front of the post office in Mounted Place, Montana. She jumped down from the driver's seat and gave a wave as her friend, Pat Horneug, honked while passing by on the main drag. Georgia grabbed a cloth bag from behind her seat and slammed the door shut. She walked into the post office and waited patiently while an elderly man finished paying for his stamps and ambled away from the counter.

The man behind the counter recognized Georgia and greeted her with a smile. "How are you this morning?"

"Good," Georgia said, "don't suppose that package came in for me?"

"Actually," the man said, grinning, "I do have something for you, yes."

Georgia smiled as the man walked into the back room and returned with a long, rectangular cardboard box.

"Here we are," he said. "Oh, looks like postage is paid, so you're all set."

Georgia noted a lady waited behind her, so she lifted the box from the counter and moved out of the way quickly. "Thank you," she said.

"Any time."

She carried the box to a counter top at the front window. She recognized the black insignia of the company stamped on the box. Tearing away a piece of the packing tape, she reached into the box and pulled out a reflective silver packet. The box was full of freeze-dried food divided into individual packets for each meal. Georgia read the bold-faced type on the front of the packet and frowned. She fished her cell phone from her pocket and called her husband, Glen.

"Yeah, it's me, I'm at the post office. Glen, they sent the wrong ones again. These are the 10-year, not the 20."

She waited for Glen to stop ranting about how many times the survival food packaging company had screwed up their order.

"Do you want me to return to sender? Or what should I do?"

Glen said not to bother and just bring those ones home. In their survival preparations, they had always opted for survival food that would keep for as

long as possible. Still, the feeling was the 10 year packets would be good enough rather than bother sending the order back.

“Alright, I'll bring 'em,” Georgia said, “I'll stop and check on Jinny at the vet's too and then I'll be on my way. Talk to you in a bit.”

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INGRID & URSULA ODENSHAW

HARPA CONFERENCE CENTER

REYKJAVIK, ICELAND

4:05 PM LOCAL TIME

Ingrid Odenshaw glanced down at her notes and noticed her hand was a bit shaky. Her daughter, Ursula, plopped down on the couch beside her. “Nervous?” She said, in an annoyingly cheerful voice.

“No more so than usual,” her mother replied.

Ingrid thought back to the Democratic National Convention in Memphis where she gave a speech introducing her husband, Samuel, a few months before he won the Presidency. She remembered the enthusiasm of the crowd and feeling more of a warm buzz of excitement than any feelings of nervousness. This time was different however. She was in Iceland to address the Women's World Progress Summit as the keynote speaker from a panel of other female leaders. It was her first major speaking event since becoming First Lady. She didn't want to let on to her teenage daughter that she was actually terror-stricken thinking that admitting it out loud might make the awful feelings worse.

“I'm fine,” Ingrid said. “How about you? Are you having a good time?”

“Yeah,” Ursula said, “I guess.”

One of the organizers, wearing headphones and carrying a clipboard, was allowed to pass into the back room by Secret Service. She walked over to Ingrid and Ursula.

“Miss, we're ready for you. As we discussed, you'll be speaking fourth.”

Ingrid and Ursula stood up. The First Lady swept her hands over her suit. The organizer checked the microphone clipped to the inside of Ingrid's top and made sure the battery pack attached at the back of her suit was in place. The organizer looked at Ursula. “We have a seat for you beside the stage, miss.”

“Thank you.”

Ingrid turned and gave her daughter a weary smile.

“You're gonna do great, mom,” Ursula said.

They shared a hug and Ingrid turned and followed the organizer out of the room.

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WES POLLARD

OFFICES OF ROSE ATLANTIC CAPITAL
NEW YORK CITY, NEW YORK
12:05 PM LOCAL TIME

With his fingers furiously tapping at his keyboard, Wes Pollard touched his earpiece, his eyes scanning the figures racing across his screen.

"Yeah, I know," he said into his mic, "are you seeing this? Gold's gonna bottom today. I'm telling you."

He listened to the reedy voice on the other end of the call. A frantic commodities trader looking to short his precious metals position.

"No," Wes said, "I've said it, how many times now? How many times have I told you this is a buying opportunity."

The man on the other continued ranting.

"No," Wes interrupted, "you gotta grab this, I'm saying you gotta grab it with both hands. Do you understand?"

Again the man on the other end wasn't agreeing.

"Hey," Wes said, "that's fine. Look, you do what you gotta do, but me? I'm going back in. Double. No, hell with that. Triple."

The trader on the other end told Wes he was crazy and hung up. Wes ripped his earpiece off and tossed it onto his desk, swiveling around in his chair to look out at the Manhattan skyline. "Idiot," he mumbled to himself. He heard a knock on the glass behind him. He turned and saw Pete Klein, one of the other traders on the floor, looking in on him. Pete could see Wes's tie hanging loose and the top button on his collar undone.

"Rough morning?" Pete asked.

"You could say that, yeah."

"Me and the boys are thinking about hittin' up that new lobster joint over on Water if you're interested."

"Nah, I've got a few more calls to make," Wes said, "you guys go ahead."

"Alright. You sure, man? You look like you could use a break."

"I'm all good. Let me know how it is."

"Okay, man."

Pete walked away and Wes rolled his chair back to his desk and stared at the numbers on his monitor. Frustrated by the figures glaring back at him he was overcome with a feeling of helplessness. "Forget this," he said to

himself. “Hey Pete!” He shouted at the glass wall in front of him. Pete heard him though and came to Wes's office door. “Changed my mind,” Wes said. “I'm comin' with you.”

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DARLA STARR

5TH AVENUE

SEATTLE, WASHINGTON

9:05 AM LOCAL TIME

Darla finished washing her face and she gave herself a slight smile in the mirror before dabbing the water from her pale skin with a crisp white towel. A beep emanated from her phone. She recognized the tone meant she had a paying customer waiting for her live feed. One of many. She was dressed in a white tank top and white gym shorts. Most of her high rise apartment was decorated in minimalist white. The unit consisted of one large open concept area with her bedroom and ensuite bathroom attached. The brown stained hardwood floor and the gray stone counter tops and fixtures were the only colors other than white in the entirety of the place.

Darla looked out over the cloud-covered city through the sheer curtains. Her king-sized bed sat next to a wall of glass thirty floors up from street level. A white laptop sat on the duvet. Darla adjusted the cameras mounted on their tripods, one at the foot of the bed, the other at the side. With the click of a button she engaged the microphones as well.

She laid down on the bed and touched the space bar on her computer and could see the small square images along one side of the screen. The faces of men, mostly, who'd paid their monthly membership fee to Darla Starr's website, giving them exclusive live webcam feeds from her apartment. For \$9.99 per month, thousands of men had the privilege of watching Darla pleasure herself on her bed. Sometimes with toys, sometimes without.

Another beep from her phone and she could see on her laptop screen there were more than four thousand people watching. She smiled coyly and gave a small wave looking directly into the camera. She still got a mighty thrill from watching the reactions of those viewing her sessions. Many of the watchers waved back, grinning ear-to-ear, eager with anticipation. Her lips appeared dark in contrast with the translucence of her face and they curled in a wide smile, her bright blue eyes, aided by colored contacts widened inviting the watchers in, teasing them with what was to come.

"Shall we begin?" She said in a cheerful tone.

She giggled as she saw many heads nodding in reply on her laptop screen. Sitting up slightly, she reached behind her back and removed her

tank top.

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THE HOLDEMAN FAMILY

HIGHWAY 598

15 km EAST OF ROCKY MOUNTAIN HOUSE, ALBERTA

10:05 AM LOCAL TIME

Constable Bryan Holdeman of the Rocky Mountain House RCMP leaned against the passenger side of his police cruiser, arms laying outstretched on the vehicle's roof, watching brilliant orange flames lick against the cloudless morning sky. An abandoned barn burned across the other side of the highway, completely engulfed, the charred boards crackled, sparks snapped embers off into the grass surrounding the structure. Holdeman and the other first responders stood and watched while the volunteer firefighters clustered together coming up with a plan of attack to fight the blaze.

Constable Terry Allen hopped out of his Crown Victoria and sauntered over to where Holdeman was standing. "Hell of a fire," he said, "can feel the heat from here."

"Yep," Holdeman replied. "They'll be a while putting this one out. Good thing there's no wind."

Allen scuffed his boots into the gravel on the shoulder of the highway and slid his hands into his pockets. Both of them smiled as the owner of a local restaurant they frequented passed through all the parked emergency vehicles and gave them an awed expression as he went.

Allen turned his attention back to the fire and nodded at the derelict structure. "Deliberate or what?"

"Hard to say," Bryan answered, "wasn't in use before. Doubt it was insured."

"We know the owner?"

"Couldn't tell ya off the top of my head."

"Could be those Warski brothers," Allen offered, "remember that arena fire, couple years back? They did that one. Thought there might've been another we liked 'em for too."

"Be worth looking at, I suppose."

"What else you got going on today?" Allen said.

"Not a lot. Taking off early. Gotta take Cassie into Edmonton, see the cancer specialist."

"Damn. Everything alright?"

“Think so, yeah. She did good on the radiation. Immune system's a bit run down is all. Hasn't been feeling the best. We're gonna check things out anyway.”

“Hope it goes well, brother.”

“Me too.”

The two officers watched as the firefighters split up from their huddle and started pulling hoses from three of their trucks. Bryan's eyes followed the huge gray plume billowing out from the barn's roof up into the sky, wondering to himself just how high the smoke would carry.

HELENA HILLEN

PAWEO PALMS ASSISTED LIVING FACILITY
KAUMAKANI, HAWAII
6:05 AM LOCAL TIME

The nursing home staff responded to unit 17 quickly upon discovering Walter Johnson's daughter and granddaughter had broken the rules and spent the night in the elderly man's quarters. Johnson's daughter, Nancy and her young daughter, Libby were given away by Libby's puppy who began barking around 5:30. The dog's presence in the facility was also an abuse of the rules which stated no pets allowed outside of sanctioned animal visitation sessions scheduled for one hour each week. Walter himself, still in a coma and kept alive by machines, was visited everyday by his daughter. This was however, the first time six-year old Libby had seen her grandfather having been too young to remember him before his nasty fall.

Paweo Palms security stood outside Walter Johnson's unit waiting for Nancy to gather her things. The assistant director of the facility, Max Tremell stood next to his guards, fuming at Nancy's blatant disregard for the regulations. Nancy walked out of the unit, her hair a mess, clutching her handbag.

"You realize this will be brought to the board," Max sneered, "we may have your father removed from our care over this incident."

Nancy glared at the man. She never did like the staff at the Paweo Palms and felt they handled the residents there without tenderness. She deigned not to respond to Max's threat. "Where's my daughter?" She said, looking up and down the narrow corridor.

Helena Hillen, a resident in unit 14 opened her eyes, waiting for them to adjust in the early morning light. When the blur came into focus she could see a little girl before her, holding a small gray pitbull pup. A dream, she thought. I'm a girl again. No. This is my girl. My child. I don't dream up children. She is mine.

"Hi," the little girl said to the elderly woman. "I'm Libby."

Helena managed a feeble smile, wishing to move and perhaps sit up but unable to summon the strength so soon after waking. "Libby," she murmured. "So pretty." My child, she thought to herself. My Libby. The

silver stallion approves, was her next thought. The beautiful horse. The most beautiful. He sees what I see.

Libby held her puppy out in front of her. "This is Rico," she said. "He's a baby."

My baby, Helena thought. Part of the silver stallion. Part of us. She turned her eyes up above her bed to the silver bust of a horse's head, a large paperweight that sat on the shelf. A gift from her nephew.

Libby's attention snapped to the door as Nancy let out a loud sigh upon finding her child. "There you are," she said, "you scared me to death. Don't you ever wander off like that."

"Sorry mommy."

"Mrs. Edina, you need to leave right now," Max Tremell reiterated. "These men will escort you out."

"We're going," Nancy said, pulling away from the annoying man. "I know the way."

She grabbed her daughter by the shoulder and led her out of Helena's unit. Another child leaves me, Helena thought. Libby gave the elderly woman a small wave. The security staff followed Nancy and her daughter all the way to the parking lot.

DEREK TANEV, JON ADDIS, & FREDDY WALSH

MCKINLEY AVENUE, VENICE
LOS ANGELES, CALIFORNIA
9:05 AM LOCAL TIME

Derek had one foot dangling over the side of the empty pool situated behind his house on McKinley Avenue in Venice. He laid with his long hair matted behind him on the bricks. His friends Jon and Freddy laid nearby.

"This is my least favorite time. Like, right now," Derek said.

"You kidding me?" Jon said, "I think this is best time of day. That's why they picked the work day to start right now you know?"

"Who picked?" Freddy said, passing what was left of his joint over to Derek.

"They did," Jon said, "the powers-that-be. They chose nine a.m. as the start of the work day. They chose the optimal time that humans were found to be their most productive."

"But lots of people start work before nine, Jonny," Freddy said.

"What's your point?"

"Well, what about those people?"

"Who cares, both of you," Derek said. "None of this is helping my hangover right now, do you get that?"

"Sorry," Freddy said.

"Forget your hangover," Jon said. "We go and grab something greasy to eat, you'll be fine."

"You paying?"

Jon sat up and over-exaggerated his motions as he patted his button up shirt and shorts. "You know me, I'm tapped. Lacey has her demands."

"She sounds expensive, Jon."

"You try having a model for a girlfriend."

"Doesn't she fold T-shirts?"

"And she occasionally wears them for the customers," Jon said, "what's your point?"

"That doesn't really qualify as being a model."

"Are we gonna go get something to eat or what?"

"Does anyone here have any money?"

No one answered.

“That's what I thought,” Derek said. “One of us needs to get a job.”

Jon flashed a dirty look over at his friend. “What did you just say?”

“A job, Jon,” Derek said, “a friggin' nine-to-five. I'm tired of us always being so broke, man.”

“That's it, give it here,” Jon said, reaching to take the joint away from Derek, “clearly, you've had enough.”

WARREN BOYD

TWO-MILE CORRECTIONAL FACILITY
SOUTH OF BELLE GLADE, FLORIDA
12:05 PM LOCAL TIME

“Chow,” the guard said, no expression in his voice. Just part of the routine. He laid the tray on the floor and slid it a few inches through the open hatch, barely tall enough for the small paper bowl of chowder to pass under.

Warren Boyd laid his book down on the mattress and swung his legs over, planting his feet on the floor. The guard watched through the window as Warren leaned forward from the bed and pulled the tray to himself across the concrete floor. A paper plate of fish sticks and a small clump of peas next to the paper bowl of chowder and a dinner roll. No utensils. Warren recognized the guard, Rodriguez. No nonsense, but usually fair. He bit into the bun and dipped it into the chowder. Usually the soups served in the prison were flavorless, but he noted an extra bit of saltiness this time, and he appreciated it.

“New chef?” Warren said.

Rodriguez didn't acknowledge him.

“Tough crowd.” Warren picked up a fish stick and popped the whole thing into his mouth, chewing with his mouth open, loud. “You're gonna miss me when I'm gone,” Warren said, sending bits of fish spewing outward, “I just know it. Secretly, you love having me around.”

“Hurry up and finish,” Rodriguez said.

The instruction only caused Warren to chew more slowly. He was already on Death Row, he figured. What else could they do to him? Warren was one of 350 prisoners awaiting the needle in the state of Florida, and he was all out of appeals. Mind you, it didn't help Warren's bids for freedom that he confessed to butchering 18 women over a period of 12 years, just as it was difficult for anyone to believe his claims of innocence when he eventually led police to all the places their body parts were buried. As with everything else in his life, he enjoyed making others suffer, and dragging out proceedings in court was just another way he'd found to aggravate. No more. The last of his appeals fell through and he was left to sit in a 6x10 cell until the state could get around to ending him.

Some had argued a life sentence would be better given he was in his mid-forties and in good health. It would give him time to sit and stew over what he'd done. To live with the regret. The thing those folks didn't understand was that Warren Boyd was incapable of regret, a true psychopath. He enjoyed killing and torture and felt no guilt about it whatsoever. The only problem in his eyes is that he got caught.

He tilted the paper plate in front of his mouth and swallowed the peas as they dropped into his mouth. He sopped up the last of his chowder with the final bite of his roll and tossed the empty paper dishes onto the tray.

"Slide it out," Rodriguez instructed.

"Hang on," Warren said, never one to fully cooperate. He took the small paper bowl and held it under the tiny tap jutting from the wall over the aluminum sink. He filled the bowl with water and took a drink. Then he poured the water over his hands and wiped them through his salt-n-pepper beard. He could've washed the crumbs of food from his beard from just the tap alone, but that wouldn't have wasted the guard's time.

"Here you go," Warren said, a sly grin on his face as he slid the tray back out through the hatch on the floor.

Rodriguez collected the tray full of empty receptacles and disappeared from Warren's view. Warren let out a content sigh and sat back down on his bed, lifting up his book and finding the place on the page where he'd left off.

ADELE MYJINSKI

NAVAL AIR STATION SLOAN
12 MILES SOUTHWEST OF LAS VEGAS, NEVADA
9:05 AM LOCAL TIME

Lieutenant Adele Myjinski, call sign “Magic”, walked in her flight suit with her helmet under her arm. She strolled across the concrete plaza to the hangar where technicians finished their pre-flight checks on her F/A-18C Hornet.

“Magic!” Her superior, Commander Dominguez, called to her from across the plaza. She turned toward him as he jogged over. “Was hoping to catch you before you were in the air,” he said.

“What's going on, Commander?”

“Just got off the phone with Captain Tibbetts. Your transfer's been granted.”

Adele's face lit up. “You're kidding?”

Dominguez smiled. “For my own sake, I wish I was.” He held out his hand. “Congratulations, Lieutenant.”

She gulped and a tear formed in the corner of her eye. Before shaking the man's hand she gave him a salute which he returned in kind.

“That's all, Lieutenant,” he said, turning to walk back to base. “I wanted to let you know as soon as I knew.”

“Thank you, Commander.”

“Don't mention it. Have a good flight, Magic. Now officially your last patrol with the 859th,” he added with a smile. “Enjoy it.”

Adele practically hopped as she made her way over to her plane. Three hours of work then it was off to San Diego.

PHILIP & CHARLES STIRLING

ABOARD TIDINGS FISHING VESSEL

195 km SOUTHEAST OF LUNENBURG, NOVA SCOTIA

1:05 PM LOCAL TIME

Philip Stirling finished the last bite of his cheese sandwich before checking the riggings one last time as the first gales of the summer storm came through. His father Charles, the only other soul aboard their small fishing boat looked on from the wheel. Philip could see the worry in his old man's eyes as whitecaps rolled higher and higher with each passing minute. They were still a lengthy ride from home on the South Shore, closer to Sable Island than they were the mainland.

"Get on your suit," Charles said, referring to the dry suit hanging nearby.

"You too."

"Don't worry 'bout me. Just get it on."

It wasn't their first storm at sea by any stretch, but as much as Philip knew his father was a risk-taker when a big catch was involved, he also could tell by Charles' demeanor that he was thinking he might have bitten off more than he could chew this time. The forecasts had called for gale force winds, but it was only when they were within 40 km of their final pull that Environment Canada upgraded the strength to storm force. Charles told his son to expect winds up to 50 knots. If that forecast held up, it'd be the strongest the old man had experienced since his time as a teenager on a freighter in the Gulf of Mexico. As it was they were already riding up and down on 18 foot seas.

Philip walked to a floor hatch near the stern, even as the wind whipped spray past his ears he could still hear the strains of 80s music coming from the old radio hanging on a nail from the bulkhead. The clouds overhead had gathered fast and loomed like charcoal ghosts, the wind and water seemed to become more violent by the second. Charles dropped the brave act for a moment and let go of the wheel long enough to grab the bin containing his dry suit.

"Better get mine on too, I think."

No sooner had Philip donned his orange survival suit when a forceful gust doubled him over and he heard his father holler from twenty feet away. The sound of Charles crying out caused Philip's heart to jump to his throat,

then he nearly fainted when he looked past the standing shelter and saw the cause of the old man's distress.

“Philip! Grab on, son!”

Philip could barely register his father's words. Before him, a few hundred feet off their bow lingered a gray wall of water tall as an office tower, rising out of the depths like a dark demon out to swallow the world. A rogue wave? Philip barely had time to think, he and his father stood there exposed, their 50 footer slid down the back of a twenty foot swell. Charles wrapped his hand in a length of pale rope knotted to the sheerline. Philip crawled to the bulkhead, grabbed a metal handle bolted to it with both hands and looked in horror at the monster over head.

The two men watched as the giant surge seemed to roll toward them in slow motion, throwing them into darkness, a tiny matchstick bobbing in the shadow of a watery beast.

TRENTON CHAMBERS

TUSCOLA PENITENTIARY

TWO MILES WEST OF TUSCOLA, TEXAS

11:05 AM LOCAL TIME

“Four aces,” Hector Sanchez smiled, laying his cards on the blue metal table in the Tuscola prison yard. The stiff Texas breeze flipped over the ace of hearts. The hot sun beat down on the two hundred men scattered across the brown dirt, ringed by high brick walls patrolled by uniformed men carrying high-powered rifles.

“Man, quit cheatin’,” Jesse Bradshaw said in disgust, tossing his hand down on the hard surface.

Trenton Chambers chuckled at the young man while folding his cards into his palm. Sweat poured off his forehead and he flinged away a bead of it with his thumb. “Beat you fair and square.” He said to Jesse. “What'd you have?”

“I ain't tellin’.”

“Nobody likes a sore loser, man,” Hector said. He reached out and scooped up the last of Jesse's cigarettes.

“To hell with this.” Jesse got up from the bench that was bolted to the concrete and he walked away in anger. Both Hector and Trenton shook their heads.

“He's got a hot head,” Hector said.

“Yep. He'll learn. He's got time.”

“Just like the rest of us, hey?” Hector said. “What'd you have?”

Trenton turned over his cards.

“Pair of Jacks, that's it?” Hector looked at him, confused. “Why you stay in on that?”

Trenton laughed. “That's a good hand most of the time. How'd I know you'd come up with a miracle?” He slid the last of his smokes across to Hector.

“Because I'm good, homes.”

“Uh huh. You keep tellin' yourself that. Talk to ya.” Trenton swung his tired legs over the bench and stood up. He swiped dust from his light blue coveralls and walked over to one of the friendlier guards, Gynkowski. The guard kept his eyes up, scanning the yard for any signs of trouble. He held

his hands near his belt line, prepared. Trenton sidled up to him with a sly grin. "What's on for chow today, boss?"

"Oh, you know, the usual."

"Gray potatoes and brown peas?"

"You guessed it."

"You know one of these days they're gonna surprise me and serve us prime rib."

"In your dreams, Chambers."

"I tell ya what, Gynkowski. When I get outta here, first I'm gonna sue the state for locking up an innocent man, and then I'm gonna take 'em to court for cruel and unusual punishment serving that slop to us everyday."

"You need someone to go in on it with you? Make it a class action kinda deal?"

"You'd do that, Gynkowski?"

"Anything to help. You know how I do."

"Let me guess what you're havin' for lunch, big man. A nice, juicy steak back at the guard shack."

"Close. The wife's bringin' me a Big Mac."

"And fries?"

"Of course."

"You're a lucky man, Gynkowski, don't let anyone tell ya any different." Trenton walked to the water fountain nearby.

"Don't I know it," the guard replied.

Chambers greeted a couple of other prisoners and bent down to grab a drink. The water poured lukewarm against his parched lips, but he didn't care. Anything to beat the heat. He wiped water droplets from his mouth and looked out to the basketball court where a crowd of younger men feigned interest in their game, mostly wilting though in the midday August heat.

Trenton was older than a lot of inmates and he still had another seven years on what he termed a 'bullshit charge'. Heroin trafficking is what the assistant D.A. tried to get to him to admit, but even though his arresting officers, the county and the state believed he was a dealer, he knew he was innocent, they were using him as a scapegoat and for seven more years that would have to be enough. Maybe if he could've afforded a real lawyer instead of relying on a wet behind the ears public defender he might've beaten the rap. Maybe. He'd be 56 by the time he'd be out, all he could do

was try to make the best of things.

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MAGGIE STONE

HIGHWAY 201

3 km EAST OF RED RIVER FIRST NATION, MANITOBA

11:05 AM LOCAL TIME

Maggie Stone pulled her sunglasses from the holder in front of the sunroof, squinting until she had her shades on. She could hear her daughter, Rosie, giggle from the passenger seat of the Dodge Ram.

"They make you look funny," Rosie said.

"I think they're nice."

She was within 2 kilometres of Dominion City where members of her nation had formed a blockade at the junction of the 200 and 201 highways. She felt nervous the closer she got to the site. As band Chief she knew she'd be looked to for guidance and she also knew from the calls she'd received that morning that the local RCMP would be out in force.

"I need you to stay in the truck when we get there, okay?" Maggie said to her daughter.

"Why? I wanna talk to Kiara."

"Kiara's not going to be there. She's with her mother."

"Nuh-uh," Rosie said. "She sent me a text."

"I thought I told you you were grounded from using your phone? You remember that?"

"I had to, Mom."

"Sure. You had to."

Up ahead on the flat horizon, Maggie could see the silhouette of police cruisers occupying the shoulders of the highway on both sides. "Here we go," she mumbled to herself.

She slowed her vehicle as she approached an RCMP pickup truck parked horizontally across the highway, still another 900 metres from the blockade site. She rolled down her window as a large police woman walked over, her deadened expression signaled a kind of seriousness that worried the Chief.

"Good morning," the RCMP officer said, looking judgmentally into the cab of Maggie's truck. "You're Chief Stone?"

"Yes," Maggie said.

"This your daughter?"

"That's right."

“Might not have been the best idea to bring her here, you know that right?”

“Her father's at work,” Maggie said, “and I'm sure you know the school's closed because of all of this.”

“Right, okay,” the officer said as though she was half-listening. She looked away from Maggie's truck for a moment to a group of officer's dressed in tactical gear a few hundred metres farther up the road. Then she turned her attention back to Maggie. “So, what's your intention here? Are you going up there to speak with your council, or?”

“I'm going to talk to whoever's there,” Maggie said. “I don't really know who's there right now. I'll know more when I get there.”

“Uh-huh,” the officer said. “We just hope you understand our position, okay? We want to make sure we end this thing peacefully.”

“Of course,” Maggie said, though in her heart she resented the police's strong show of force. “That's what I want as well.”

“Okay, well hopefully with you up there we can get this thing calmed down and maybe we can send folks home, you know?”

“I'll see what I can do, officer,” Maggie said. “These are my people, but obviously I'm not promising anything. I understand what they want. We've been lobbying the government for a fix to our water treatment for a long time now.”

“I understand that,” the officer said in the kind of assertive tone that basically expressed the opposite, “but you have to understand this a public highway, right?”

“Yes.”

“We have to be able to allow people through.”

“I get it.”

“Okay, well, let's hope we can resolve this, alright?”

“Yep.”

The officer stepped away, and Maggie slid her window back up and turned up the air conditioning. She wheeled her pickup around the RCMP truck and slowly coasted past the armed tactical officers towards the large crowd gathered at the intersection up ahead.

“She didn't seem nice,” Rosie said.

“She's doing her job,” Maggie said. “And, she might not be nice.”

“If the Magic One was here she could fly them all away,” Rosie said.

“Rosie,” her mother scolded.

“What? She could.”

“I don't want to hear anymore about the Magic One, okay? Especially not today.”

“She can make things fly, with her mind. She's a thousand miles away from here, but if she was here, she could do it.”

“Rosie! What did I just say?”

Maggie reached the first throng of faces she recognized from the reserve. One of the elders, Chester Fox walked toward her pickup. She pulled the vehicle off the side of the highway into the yellow grass. Chester walked over along with a few other locals. Maggie looked at her daughter before opening her door. “What did I tell you earlier?”

“To stay in the truck,” Rosie said.

“Right. So what are you going to do?”

“Stay in the truck.”

“Good.”

Maggie smiled at her daughter and opened the door, ready to face an angry crowd.

KEITH OLDHAM

THE CAPITAL GARDEN PLAZA HOTEL
TORONTO, ONTARIO
12:05 PM LOCAL TIME

Keith Oldham, one of the Plaza's doormen and valets, checked his watch as he stood inside the automatic sliding door, his back to the hotel lobby. Luther Wood, an old hand at the bell desk, approached him holding a set of keys hanging from a card.

"Got one for you," Luther said to Keith, about twenty years his junior. Luther passed him the keys. Keith read the card and saw "Mr. Miller, Room 312" written in blue ink. "This is Mr. Miller," Luther said, "he phoned ahead, said he'd be down in five minutes."

"Okay, great."

"You know about him?"

Keith looked at the checkin date on the card. "This guy checked in three weeks ago?"

"Yeah," Luther said, "here for a conference, and a bike race too."

"I don't think I've dealt with him before. Wasn't here when he checked in."

"Oh, well, just to let you know," Luther said, "this guy's a bit of a problem. Complains about a lot of stuff, you know what I'm saying? Was here with his wife. Both of them, nothing but whining."

"Okay, I'll keep that in mind."

Keith looked at the card again and frowned. "This says 'LD'. Loading dock? Why isn't his car parked down below?"

"You got me," Luther said, "nobody tells me a thing around here. Just be real careful with his ride, alright? And I'd bring it around now. You make him wait, you can forget a tip."

"Gotcha."

Keith through the sliding door, past the workers applying new tiles to the courtyard, down to the loading dock. There he saw the reason Mr. Miller's car wasn't taken all the way down into the parking garage. The vehicle, an Audi sedan, had a bike rack attached to its roof. Too tall for the garage. Over the six-foot clearance. Makes sense, Keith thought to himself. Still, he doubted Mr. Miller would've appreciated his car sitting in such close

proximity to where garbage dumpsters were routinely emptied and loading dock workers flicked their spent cigarettes.

Keith gave a friendly wave to one of the hotel employees finishing a smoke break nearby, seated on a milk crate. He unlocked the red A6 and started it up. As he looked around the car's luxurious interior, the thought of bikes standing on the vehicle's roof left his mind and he put the sedan in gear. While the workers were renovating the hotel courtyard, he'd become accustomed to taking vehicles out through the parking garage door on the other side of the building. No big deal, but he forgot, the other door had the same low clearance as the garage below. Obviously, someone parked Mr. Miller's car in the loading dock before the renovations had started so the bikes on the roof weren't a concern then. But, Keith was so enamored with the Audi's luxurious interior, the bikes weren't a concern of his either. Not a care in his mind, Keith drove up the ramp toward the open door with the low clearance.

He zoomed the Audi up the ramp towards daylight, stopped suddenly by a sickening crunch and a loud scrape from above.

Oh my god, he thought. Please, no.

He hopped out of the car, horrified as he saw the bikes had rammed into the garage ceiling above the door. One of the expensive bikes hung from the roof rack with its frame twisted, another had its handlebars pushed downward almost touching the crossbar. Beyond repair. Worse, he saw the roof of the Audi dented beneath where the bike rack had been attached. Thick, deep indents where there should have been none. The worker who had been sitting at the loading dock came running up to Keith as he stood there in absolute dread.

"Whoa," the worker said, "this is crazy that you did that, man. That's expensive, man," the worker said. "That's thousands in damage right there. Can't believe you did that."

"Thousands?"

"Yeah, man, big time. You really screwed up. Good luck."

Keith could feel his pits moisten with sweat. A chill ran down his back. He pictured his boss yelling at him, firing him. He imagined this already difficult guest absolutely losing his temper and tearing a strip off of him. This was an Audi A6. Those racing bikes were crazy expensive. He knew the hotel carried insurance for mishaps with guests' property, but what if

they docked the money required from his pay? How would he keep up on his rent? Am I going to lose my apartment? My job? His mind raced.

He closed the car door and walked back down the ramp. He left the car sitting there in front of the entrance/exit. The mangled bikes hung in place. Keith walked past the loading dock and up the hotel ramp, back into the lobby and to the Concierge desk where his boss stood in front of a computer terminal.

“What's up?” Keith's boss, Ben, said in a friendly manner. “Is Mr. Miller's car ready? Should be down any minute.”

“Uh,” Keith opened his mouth to speak, but he hardly uttered a word.

“What, man? Spit it out,” Ben said.

Keith shook out his arms trying to rid himself of adrenaline, and took a deep breath, setting the car keys on the marble counter top between them.

“Well, Ben,” Keith said, “here's the thing.”

CLARA TIERNEY

CENTRAL KALAHARI GAME RESERVE
41 MILES NORTH OF KIKAO, BOTSWANA
6:05 PM LOCAL TIME

A crispness entered the evening air, carried on a light breeze, passing over Clara Tierney's bare arms as she laid in the savanna grass, her camera steady, trained on a male giraffe keenly interested in her presence. The animal had stopped feeding from an acacia tree and turned its head. Clara didn't wish to spook the male and though she could feel the evening's briskness coming on, she did not want to risk reaching for her sweater.

Static came through her radio, then a male voice, her First A.D., Simon. "Clara, the guide is recommending we go back to the lodge, over."

Clara rolled her eyes. She'd never met a more skittish guide. She pulled the radio close and spoke softly, keeping her eyes trained on the giraffe. "Negative," she said, "I'm in a great position here. This is usable footage, over."

"I understand," Simon said, "but he says there's a pride of lions close by. Might be a wise idea to steer clear, yeah?"

Clara let out a sigh. As much as she wanted to stay put, she did recognize the danger she could've been placing the rest of her crew in were she to ignore the guide's advice. She slowly pushed herself off the ground. The giraffe, as expected, thought the better of sticking around and strolled away. Clara lifted the radio to her mouth. "Tell him I'm coming," she said. "Be there in a few, over."

DENNIS KING

STONEWALL PARK – HOME OF THE CHARLOTTE SPIRIT
CHARLOTTE, NORTH CAROLINA
12:05 PM LOCAL TIME

Batting practice had just ended at the stadium and a throng of kids and autograph hounds gathered along the wall at first base line seeking a signature from the best player in the game, Dennis King. “King!” They called out to the good-natured superstar who'd been hanging around the cage watching his teammates take their turns at the plate. With a smile and his usual easy going way, he ambled over to the crowd followed by a few photographers working for local media. He accepted a Sharpie pen and a Philadelphia ball cap from a ten-year old boy. “What's your name?” He asked the kid. Then he signed the underside of the cap's bill, handing it and the pen back.

This was Dennis's first visit to Charlotte since the expansion team began play back in the spring. Already a legend in Philadelphia where he was only five years into his career, fans flocked to watch him play wherever he went, and Charlotte was no different.

“Can you sign this one for my daughter?” A Charlotte fan asked, handing him a Charlotte Spirit game program.

“No problem.”

Ten minutes later he was called away by a handler for the Philadelphia ball club as Dennis was booked for a brief interview with members of the national baseball media prior to that afternoon's game slated to start in under an hour. Following the interview, during which he spoke genially about his manager and his teammates and conducted himself in the same 'boring' way some members of the media had said made him less of a marketable star than would be needed for the continued growth of the sport, he sauntered into the visiting clubhouse to find the buffet table. The rest of the team had ended batting practice and already found their way to the catering.

As per usual, he headed straight for the junk food, something his teammates always poked fun of him for, yet his physique belied his poor dietary decisions. At six foot one, 230 pounds and little body fat, most attributed his build to youth. He was still just twenty-five years old.

“Someday you're gonna be fat as hell,” his teammate, Eric Foster, the team's starting catcher said pointing at Dennis's side plate holding two powdered donuts.

Dennis chuckled at the comment. He was used to the ribbing. “Yeah, yeah. We'll see.” Two donuts, that was his current norm. Just like all ball players, Dennis was notoriously superstitious. For the previous ten days he'd been on a hot streak at the plate, four home runs, six extra-base hits. He chalked some of his good fortune up to his new habit of eating two sugary donuts roughly a half-hour before game time.

“What are ya gonna do when those stop workin', bro?” Dennis's buddy, the second-baseman Scott Rodmeier asked, half-joking.

“I don't even know what you're talking about,” Dennis said. “It's not possible.”

“Whatever, bro. Straight to the minors. The mighty King, down he goes. I'll cry for ya, man.”

Dennis gave him a shove and walked over to his locker just as their manager walked in, ready to quickly address the squad before they walked out to the field.

MICHAEL JANVIER & ELIZA CHAMPION

AMETHYST CAY RESORT
TURKS AND CAICOS
12:05 PM LOCAL TIME

Gazing out of his villa at the turquoise water and white sand before him, Michael Janvier was taken by surprise when a uniformed resort employee entered the room behind him to retrieve what was left of breakfast. Michael frowned slightly then waved his hands in an outward motion as if to rush the staff along carrying plates of half-eaten eggs and fruit out of the villa.

"Yes," he said, lacking patience, "go." He glanced at his cell phone laying on a gold side table and contemplated calling his agent in New York, then decided not to as he heard Eliza turn off the shower. He walked into the spacious en suite wearing only a robe. Eliza Champion, also an "A" list actor and his lover, though that was not public knowledge. Yet. She quickly grabbed a towel when she saw him and wrapped herself.

"I was going to join you," Michael said.

"Were you?"

"I was." He put his arm around her and leaned in for a kiss.

She kissed him and patted his beard. "When does this go?" She said, referring to his thick facial hair.

"Reshoots in six weeks, you knew that."

"Six weeks," she said in an exasperated tone. "Did you call Eli?" She walked to the mirror, leaned in close to it and wasn't pleased to notice slight redness in one eye.

"Not yet," Michael replied. "We're back in a week." He stepped over to her again and pulled at the back of her towel.

Eliza smiled slightly and stopped him. "Not right now," she said.

Michael, annoyed, sniffed and turned away. "What did you want to do then?"

"Was thinking of checking out the shops."

"You want me to come with you?"

"Only if you want to."

"They don't make disguises good enough."

"You think it would be that bad?"

“Please,” Michael said, “the vultures would be out for just one of us. For both? A nightmare.”

“No one knows we're here together, thank God.”

“Could you imagine?”

Michael's phone buzzed to life in the other room. He whisked in to pick it up, seeing his agent's face on the display. “Eli,” he said to Eliza before answering. “I swear the man's psychic.”

After two minutes of what sounded like pained conversation, Michael hung up. Eliza was in the walk-in closet getting dressed. “That didn't sound pleasant,” she said. “Is it about the production credit?”

“Yes, and he wants me in Paris next week to meet with a financier.”

“Is this for that new project?”

He smiled condescendingly at her. “You know I can't discuss this with you right now.”

She pursed her lips and raised an eyebrow. He knew what that look meant.

“You know that, right?” He said.

“I guess,” Eliza said, and she sighed. “Okay, fine, yes - I know. But it's not as if I'm begging for a role. I was genuinely curious.”

“We'll do a project together,” Michael said, “maybe after the world finds out about us.”

“I would rather avoid that.”

The comment took Michael aback, it stung him a little, but he wouldn't let on. “Me too,” he lied.

“What else did Eli say?” Eliza said, “you sounded annoyed at the end there.”

“He's worried about the weather.”

“The weather?”

“Something about a tropical depression near Africa. These things have a habit of becoming hurricanes or something. I don't know. Whatever,” Michael said, waving the notion away. “He already knows, we'll have left this place well before it's an issue. I'm not worried, but I guess he is.”

“That's what makes him Eli,” Eliza said.

“Indeed.”

BOB ANGEL

HENDERSON CONVENTION CENTER
NEW ORLEANS, LOUISIANA
11:05 AM LOCAL TIME

Bob Angel hated giving speeches. He read over notes he'd transposed onto blue index cards while his leg jiggled, seated at the Henderson Convention Center's cafe in the main lobby. Noticing his shaking, he tried to relax, remembering what his therapist had said about taking himself too seriously. He tried to make light of his nerves. Too much espresso, he told himself. Though really his nerves had been getting the best of him since the night before when he'd checked into his hotel.

It was the third year Bob had attended the Titans of Emerging Tech conference, the third straight year he'd been asked to deliver one of the key speeches for the event, and his first visit to New Orleans. Taking the last bite of his croissant and noticing he only had an hour left before he was to speak, Bob sped up his reading not admitting to himself that none of the words were registering in his brain. He began to murmur the words out loud when he noticed someone looming nearby. He looked up to see a pretty young woman standing next to his table. She was smiling and Bob knew that she recognized him, he was after all, the biggest name of the high profile conference invitees. Bob smiled, unsure of what to say to the woman. A billionaire with his own powerful tech company or not, he was still not the best in social situations.

"Are you here for the conference?" He said.

"Yes," the young woman tried her best to remain composed. "I'm so excited to see you here. Like, you literally have no idea."

Bob liked the attention, but then felt a pang of guilt, knowing that if this had been anyone else or say someone not this attractive he would have probably brushed them off. "That's nice of you," Bob said. "I'm just like everyone else, I assure you."

"Hardly," the young woman said, almost scoffing. "You're Bob Angel. Aren't you?"

The question and her tone threw Bob off kilter. Perhaps there was more to this exchange than he'd realized. In response to her query he nodded, but before he could say anything else to her the woman brandished a can of

mace and began to spray it all over his face, also hitting his throat, and coating the front of his shirt.

“Capitalist pig!” She screamed.

Two security guards appeared from nowhere and tackled the woman before she could completely empty the can onto him. Bob fell backward, screaming in pain as the sticky liquid scalded his skin and burned his eyes. Shocked onlookers had stopped what they were doing, frozen with fear. A few members of the Convention Center staff rushed to Bob's aid. The young woman, now being held by four guards, kicked and flailed. “Fascist!” She hollered while being dragged towards the exit.

Bob grabbed at his face and felt the burning sensation on the palms of his hands too.

“Mr. Angel,” said a woman kneeling over him. “Try to stay calm. Paramedics are coming.”

He drew in deep breaths, his mind racing. His mouth had filled with saliva and mucous. His nose ran all over. He had difficulty swallowing.

“They're on their way,” the woman tried to reassure him. “Any minute now.”

“Okay,” he said, tears streaming from his eyes, “okay.”

DASH Q

INDEPENDENCE ARENA
KANSAS CITY, MISSOURI
11:05 AM LOCAL TIME

“Yo, Dash, you want next?” Solomon Reid, one of Dash Q's bodyguards walked to the singer covered in sweat after having just finished a game of pickup basketball in one of the backrooms at Independence Arena.

Dash looked at the man and then back at his phone, a bored expression on his face. “Nah, man,” Dash said, “I'm good.”

“Oh, right,” Solomon said, “you got that interview, don't ya?”

Dash glanced to his right to the man seated in a folding chair next to him, his backup singer and best friend T.J. Grant. “T.J.,” he said, “why don't you go? Go play, man!”

“Naw dog,” T.J. said in a funny voice that caused Dash to laugh, “I'm tired.”

“You haven't played ball since we was in Boston,” Solomon said. “You scared.”

“I ain't scared,” T.J. said, “tell him D.”

Dash laughed. “You might be a little scared. Solomon's gotten real good. He's been practicing since Europe.”

“By the end of this tour I'm gonna turn pro,” Solomon said. “Believe that.”

T.J. rolled his eyes. “Now I'm gonna have to take you down,” he said, “just for that comment alone.”

Dash held out his arms. “Nah, wait. Wait. After sound check, alright? I need my boy fresh.”

“Alright.”

One of Dash's assistants, Kelsey, appeared at the far end of the massive area. “They're ready for you,” Kelsey shouted, her voice echoing through the cavernous room.

Dash jumped up from his folding chair. “Kelsey! Kelsey! Kelsey!” Dash shouted back, mocking an echo noise with his voice. “I'm coming, coming, coming!”

“Don't shout, dawg,” T.J. said in a joking tone. “Protect that voice. That's the gold, brother.”

Dash giggled, as he always did at pretty much everything T.J. said, funny or not. He wasn't looking forward to being interviewed for a local television crew, but he accepted it as part of the job and the people around him always did a good job of keeping the mood light.

“Wish me luck,” Dash said, quickly wiping wrinkles out of his silk shirt and adjusting his fedora.

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SUBJECT 736

DARPA FACILITY 88, "THE CLOVER"

1.5 MILES UNDERGROUND, 20 MILES SOUTHWEST OF
ATLANTA, GEORGIA

12:05 PM LOCAL TIME

Eric Chen could barely keep his eyes open. He leaned back in his office chair so far that it nearly tipped backward causing him to snap upward, alert once again. His co-worker Tim Ernestine, dressed in a white coat, noticed the move as he entered the room from the lab.

"Nice one," Tim said checking the monitors and looking at the gargantuan specimen laying on the other side of the thick glass, strapped to a gurney, dozens of wires protruding from his heavily-muscled, naked body. "You ever heard of sleep?" Tim said, "it's the new thing everyone's talking about."

Eric chuckled. "Tell that to my baby girl. I feel like I haven't slept in months."

"You look like it too. Take a vacation for crying out loud. Maria too for that matter."

"Would if I could," Eric said, "but who would help you take care of big boy here?"

"I'm sure they'd find someone," Tim said, chuckling, "a trained monkey perhaps."

Eric wheeled his chair to the right, double-checking the synthetic human's vital signs. He had been working on the top secret project for nearly two years, instrumental in ensuring the lab-created human matured to full size in good health and with minimal problems.

"Colonel Ward was down here yesterday," Tim said, annoyance in his tone.

"Oh yeah? How'd that go?"

"About as expected. The Pentagon wants the timeline moved up."

"What's Alice say about that?"

"Her hands are tied. Up to the Subcommittee now."

"What a mess."

"You said it."

Under a small group of Senators and Pentagon officials, the special project to build a genetically superior super-soldier was nearing completion. The government had given the hush-hush 'go ahead' to start the project nearly fifteen years prior, but the lab culture hadn't been grown from a fetus to the full-grown fourteen foot tall male laying in the deep underground facility until almost thirteen years later.

Eric continued watching the dormant giant's heart rate. They'd had the super-soldier in an induced coma since his inception, never once taking the risk to wake him. The idea was to prove growing one of these super-sized genetically superior humans was possible, with the aim of gaining approval to then perhaps clone him, begin a line of mass production and eventually replace non-synthetic humans on the field of battle altogether.

“How's he looking?” Tim said.

“Strong as ever,” Eric said, “probably still dumb as a post though.”

Tim chuckled. “You're not wrong there.”

LIN CHOU

XIANGFENG DENIM FACTORY
SHANGHAI, CHINA
12:05 AM LOCAL TIME

The foam mattress was not thick enough to give Lin Chou any comfort on the hard metal slab bolted to the factory dormitory's concrete wall. Her hip ached as she laid on her side doing her best to put the pain out of her mind so she could get at least get a few hours of sleep before 4:30 wake up time. Lin knew her mattress was not as thick as the other six ladies she shared her room with, but she was the last to visit the outlet store on Jinhui Road and the thin pad was all they had left. She hadn't had a decent night's sleep in over a year. Every night she tried harder and harder, focusing on her breathing, focusing on everyone else's breathing. But the bright beam of white light shining through the curtain-less window, the hardness of her sleeping surface, the growls of her hungry stomach. It all combined to often put her into an insomniac's trance, her thoughts drifting back to the farm where she grew up in Hunan Province, walking through fields of hemp and tobacco with her mother and father. Lin and her sister both left for the factories in the larger cities however, where the money was better, if still not great. Lin always sent half her pay back to her parents.

A cool breeze pushed in through the window giving Lin a chill. She pulled her blanket over her shoulder and the back of her neck. On an upper bunk attached to the opposite wall, Lin noticed one of her flat mates, Bai, rise and throw her feet over the side of the metal slab.

"Someone else is awake," Lin said softly.

"You are always awake, young one," Bai said, weariness in her voice. "I have to eat."

"Now? It's so late."

"My stomach aches." Bai lowered herself until her bare foot touched the edge of the bunk below her, careful not to nudge the lady sleeping there. She stepped to the cold concrete floor and crouched beneath the window on the back wall pulling an electric kettle from a plastic crate.

"Noodles?" Lin said.

"Yes. Would you like some?"

"Please."

The other women stirred, but did not wake. Bai turned to the small sink, even with the tap turned all the way only a small trickle of water flowed. She filled half the kettle and plugged into the room's only outlet. The other plug was occupied by an adapter that allowed four of the flat mates to have their phones plugged in and charging at the same time. Their phones were their only life line to the families they'd left, often hundreds of kilometers behind.

With the kettle reaching a boil, Bai unplugged it and poured the hot water into two ceramic mugs containing dried noodles. She handed one of the steaming mugs to Lin.

"Thank you," Lin said.

Quiet as mice, the two ladies sat in the gray twilight sipping from their mugs, waiting until the water would be cool enough to pick out the noodles with their hands. Spoons would have created too much noise, enough to have alerted the dorm guards and perhaps get them formally written up or worse have their kettle confiscated.

"Will you sleep after this?" Lin said.

"I will. But I know you will not. Not for two more hours."

"It is always this way."

"Not when you're older. When you leave here."

Bai, at age twenty-six, was closer to leaving the factory than Lin who'd only just turned twenty. The work was hard on the hands and wrists. Fifteen hours a day of fine snipping and cutting of loose threads on denim jeans and jackets. A lot of pulling, tightening, clipping, sewing. The long hours and lack of nutrition took a brutal toll as the months and years wore on. This reality created a high-turnover among the young workforce. It was rare to see a woman working in the Xiangfeng facility past the age of twenty-eight. By then you were considered ancient and you looked the part, bags under the eyes, crippled hands barely capable of grasping a railing. Most would return to their homes, hopefully with some semblance of savings, to live out their years in relative poverty raising crops, supplemented by the increased income they'd had before. Better that than staying on the farm through your twenties and living in absolute destitution.

Bai drained the rest of the water. She stowed the kettle away and set the mugs carefully on the floor beneath the sink. She stepped on the lower bunk again and hoisted herself up, cautious enough so as not to bump her head on the concrete ceiling only a few feet above her bunk.

“Will you leave the city after this?” Lin asked.

“No,” Bai answered softly. “I will stay.” She laid down on her thick mattress and pulled her blanket under her chin, closing her eyes, her stomach settled.

“Sleep well,” Lin whispered.

“I wish the same for you, young one.”

Lin laid on her back, crossing her arms across her chest. She stared at the bunk above her and thought about the farm.

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LISA JACKSON & GARRETT TIGNISH

BUCHANAN NUCLEAR GENERATING STATION

BUCHANAN, NEW YORK

12:05 PM LOCAL TIME

A burgundy minivan rolled to a stop at the west end of the giant parking lot in front of Buchanan Nuclear Generating Station, a nuclear power plant 30 miles north of Manhattan. Lisa Jackson, an investigative reporter with the Hudson Tribune-Press, exited from the back of the vehicle, followed by photographer Garrett Tignish. They were collaborating on a story about safety and security at the plant after an anonymous whistleblower had posted videos online purported to show lax safety standards inside the facility and talked of workers there being plagued by a host of health issues that had allegedly been covered up by Manhattan-Franklin, the energy conglomerate in charge of the station.

Adorned in hard hats and work boots, a group of plant employees, expecting the arrival of the journalists, had gathered near the facility's front entrance. They eyed Lisa and Garrett with suspicion as the two collected their things from the minivan. Lisa's cell phone blared to life. She pressed the phone to her ear and Garrett checked his camera equipment.

"Hey, Leon," Lisa said, speaking to her associate editor who was back at the office in New York. "What's up? We just arrived."

"Have you met with the liaison there yet?" Leon asked.

"No, not yet. We honestly just arrived. I see some employees out here. I'll go talk to them."

"I just wanted to give you a heads up, some of the workers there might be a little-"

A strong gust of wind pushed Lisa's hair into her face. Frustrated, she brushed it back with arm, but she'd missed the last of what Leon had said.

"Can you repeat that, Leon? Sorry, it's the wind."

"I'm saying some of the people there might be reluctant to talk."

"I expected that." Another strong gust caused Lisa's jacket to flap up. "Let me see what I can do, I should probably go though."

"Alright, stay safe."

"Yep."

Lisa pocketed her phone and threw an annoyed look at Garrett. She grabbed an elastic from her backpack and tied her hair up having lost her patience with the wind.

“What was that about?” Garrett asked.

“Leon's worried for our safety.”

“Interesting.”

The group of workers approached Lisa and Garrett. One of the men, wearing a collared dress shirt, black jeans and glasses looked at Lisa. “You here from the Hudson?”

“We are.”

“I just want to let you know, we don't know anything about what was posted, alright? But we've been told to let you guys in.”

“That's fine,” Lisa replied. “Listen, we're just here to do our job.”

“Truth is,” the man said, “we don't like you folks much up here. Media types.”

Lisa looked at Garrett who merely shrugged his shoulders.

“Follow us,” the man said.

The small group of workers fell in behind the man with the glasses and Lisa and Garrett made sure to walk toward the building a few steps behind.

“Well,” Garrett said, deadpan, “this oughta be fun.”

2.

-ZERO HOUR+

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NESTOR SINGH

ABOARD *TALCAHUANO* RESEARCH VESSEL
DRAKE PASSAGE, 300 km SOUTH OF CAPE HORN
1:05 PM LOCAL TIME

Nestor stood along the steel railing on the deck of the ship holding binoculars in front of his face. Michelle walked over. "Anything?" She said.

"Nothing."

"I guess we'll have to move to another area after all. I know you hate admitting Sergio was right."

Nestor chuckled at the suggestion. "He has to be right first," he said. "How was lunch?"

"Actually pretty good. You would've liked it."

"Oh yeah?"

"Yeah, it--"

A concussive explosion cut Michelle off mid-sentence. Loud as a sonic boom, the blast thundered across the sky though few clouds appeared above them. Nestor whipped his head right toward the source of the sound, due south. Michelle followed suit.

"Right there!" Michelle couldn't help but shout. Panic in her voice.

"I see it," Nestor replied.

The two researchers looked at one another with wide eyes, then back at what appeared to be an off-white plume on the blue horizon. Its small size and wavy outline told them it was a long way off.

Nestor flashed from the deck back inside to look at his readouts. The ship's captain, Sergio Ventura appeared from the galley below. "What the hell was that?" Sergio said.

Nestor looked at his computer screen. "An eruption of some kind. Looks like 3300 kilometers from here."

"An eruption?" Sergio said, fear in his voice. "Where?"

Nestor could hardly believe it himself as he stared at the monitor. "The South Pole."

"You're kidding," Michelle said, incredulous.

"I'm not."

With a snap and a flicker the ship went dark. Nestor's equipment turned black. The engines went deadly quiet. A commotion sounded from below

deck. "Hey, hey," Sergio bellowed, "what the hell is this?"

Nestor ran back out to the deck, looking south once again. Michelle and Sergio followed him, as others among the crew began appearing from the levels below.

One of the workers ran up to them. "Captain, we have no power and-"

"Quiet," barked Sergio. "Let Mr. Singh think."

They watched as the tiny plume seemed to connect sea and sky. Immediately, an overpowering stench permeated the air.

"Oh my God," Michelle said, "that's awful."

"Sulphur," Nestor said, "I think."

Sergio and his crew plugged their noses. A second later a sharp stinging sensation washed over everyone's skin, a burn that irritated their nostrils and ached in their throats and behind their eyes. Michelle sneezed and some of the crew members coughed, rubbing their eyes.

"Think this is related?" Michelle asked her boss.

Nestor squinted, the pain wasn't serious, but it was enough to cause his eyes to water. "I'm thinking it has to be."

"What should we do?" Sergio said.

"Where are the generators?" Nestor said. "That's what I'd like to know."

"They should've kicked in by now," the Captain said. "Without them we're dead out here."

HENRY IX OF ENGLAND

WATTA VILLAS RESORT

SRI LANKA

10:35 PM LOCAL TIME

Henry stared into the swimming pool long after the sun went down. The pool water glowed from the lights embedded in its walls. He thought about speaking with his mother back in England. He reached for his phone which had fallen between sofa cushions. The lights went out. Henry pushed the power button on his phone. It would not respond. He frowned, feeling the night breeze float in from the sea. A strong odor caused him to choke and cough. Henry swallowed and a sharp sting gripped his tongue and his nose. His eyes began to water. The stench was too much to bear. He could hear the echoes of others sneezing and sputtering in other rooms. Terence called out to Henry in the dark, closing the new King's door behind him.

“Highness?”

“Yes, I'm right here.”

Terence tried to stifle his cough. “Are you okay?”

“I'm fine. Do we know what this is?”

“No. I have shouted to the guards, no one's answering. I cannot call them. Phones are down.”

“Have they left their posts?”

“Not that I was aware. One had been trying to escort Ms. Clark back to her resort.”

“Bloody hell. She's still here?”

“Had been in the bar, Highness. Upset you see.” Terence couldn't hold back his cough any longer. He held a fist to his lips, doing his best to get it under control.

“You're worse off than I am,” Henry said. He stood from the sofa. The moon provided just enough light to see the outline of the pool in front of him. He avoided the edge and tried to see if any lights were on in other units.

“Careful, sir,” Terence said, swallowing the ache in the back of his throat.

“I'm fine.”

A knock sounded at the door. “Don't move,” Terence instructed. “Please.”

“You worry too much, Terence.” Henry said, then sneezing.

“Yes?” Terence answered through the heavy door.

“It's Marcus,” came the voice of one of Henry's bodyguards.

Terence opened the door and could barely make out the outline of the heavily muscled man. A much smaller shadow clung to him. “Who is that?” Terence said.

“Apologies, sir,” Marcus said, groaning as he rubbed his eyes, “she insisted on coming back to see him again.”

Terence knew the guard meant Clarissa. “No,” Terence said. “Absolutely not. Not now.”

He could hear the girl sniffing into the guard's arm. “Take her back downstairs at once.”

“Terence,” Henry spoke up from inside the room. “It's fine, let her in.”

Terence stepped out of the way and Marcus walked into the room with the girl careful not to bump into anything. Terence closed the door and locked it.

LAUREN SIMMS & JEFF GREENING

MAPLEVIEW LAKE CONSERVATION AREA

VINELAND, ONTARIO

1:05 PM LOCAL TIME

Jeff didn't like Lauren's hair, but that wasn't something to tell your bride the very moment you're about to marry her. He didn't like the way they tucked her blonde braid to one side. Jeff always loved it when Lauren wore her hair down.

The weather could not have been better for an outdoor wedding. Sunny skies over a green field with vineyards beyond. One hundred guests sat on white wooden fold out chairs. The only small children were the ring bearer, Lyle, and the flower girl, Brook. No babies, no small children. Those were Lauren's orders.

The DJ, Danton, had played a soft guitar instrumental from his iPod for Lauren's walk down the aisle holding the arm of her father, Bill. The song Lauren had picked out.

Three of Lauren's five bridesmaids had kicked off their shoes to stand barefoot in the grass. The wedding planner, Selena Marchant was not impressed. Remy Quinn and his catering staff looked on from a hundred feet away in front of the refurbished barn where the reception would be held. Phil Greening, one of Jeff's brothers and an usher, had handed out paper fans to guests. A slight breeze kept the humidity down a bit, but not much.

Jeff tried not to concentrate on Lauren's hair that he felt was overdone. Jeff had his Best Man Dan Resey beside him as Lauren had her Maid of Honor Lindsay Wholman beside her. Their Officiant, Tom Carkner, verse held in front of him, was ready to begin. He opened his mouth to speak and spewed a wad of phlegm onto Jeff's lapel. There was no time to gasp at the gaffe, everyone was overcome with a terrible stench. Two of Jeff's groomsmen were doubled over coughing. Lauren's Design Assistant on her TV show, and one of her bridesmaids, Holly Poole, nearly fell backward with the stinging in her eyes, her blurred vision came out of nowhere.

Back at the barn, Remy held his nose and looked all around the grounds hoping to see the source of the awful smell. His servers were holding their

throats, coughing and sneezing. He could barely speak, but he managed to bark at them to take their sputtering away from the trays of food.

The guests fanned themselves and those around them feverishly. Anything to push away the terrible odor. Lauren's grandmother, May, truly wondered if she was going to choke to death. No one knew what to do. Lauren looked away from Jeff, the back of her neck which had a slight coat of perspiration stung as though it'd been sunburned. She waved her arm, frantic, a signal for Selena to come quick. Selena, dealing with her own breathing issues, saw Lauren wave to her and pushed her way past the troubled guests until she reached the front.

"What is happening?" Lauren said to the planner.

"I don't know."

"Well find out!"

Terry, Jeff's teenage cousin who'd been forced to be an usher for the event, handled the smell and the attack on his senses better than most. He turned to his fifteen year old girlfriend beside him, Charla, the one who'd been getting dirty looks from the girl in front of her for having her feet up on the back of her chair. He grabbed her cell phone while she tried to calm her sneezing fit. Terry pressed the button on the side of the phone, but the screen remained black just like his.

"Jeffrey!" The groom turned to see his mother, Candice, fanning his dad, Randall who appeared to be passed out. Jeff rushed over.

"Is he alright?"

"I don't know," Candice said, "he just fainted all of a sudden."

Breathing seemed to get easier for most in an instant. The choking and stinging sensations ceased, though the stench remained.

Jeff wiped away the water at the corners of his eyes. "Dad," he said, touching his father's cheek. Randall's eyes opened suddenly. It took him a moment to realize where he was. Jeff smiled slightly. "Are you alright?"

"What happened?" Randall said.

"You passed out."

"I did?"

"Yes."

"Are you married now? Did I miss it? Jesus, that smell. What is that, sulphur?"

"Don't worry, Dad. You didn't miss it. Just stay here, okay. We're gonna get you looked at."

“No, don't do that, I don't want to ruin your day.”

“Dad, relax. Just want to make sure you're alright. Can somebody call a doctor?”

“An ambulance?”

“Yes.”

Jeff pulled his cell phone from his pocket. Lauren walked over to him. “Is he okay?”

“I don't know,” Jeff said, “he passed out. I hope he's fine.”

“What is happening, Jeff?”

“I wish I knew.”

Jeff looked at his phone, the screen wouldn't engage. “Does your phone work?”

Lauren turned to her Maid of Honor. “Lindsay, you have my phone, right?”

“Yep,” Lindsay walked over. “Mine's not working. Here.”

Lindsay passed Lauren her phone. It would not turn on.

Everyone in the crowd was doing a dance of sorts, a variation of tapping on their phones and watches, willing them to work.

“This is stupid,” Lauren said, she pinched her nose trying to block the smell. “I literally don't understand what is happening right now.”

“Excuse me!” Dan, the best man, waved his arms overhead to get everyone's attention. “Does anyone here have cell reception? Or a phone that works? Jeff's dad needs to see a doctor!”

Everyone shook their head. A lot of answers in the negative were shouted.

“Unbelievable,” Dan said, “nobody's phone works.”

“I'm fine, seriously,” Randall said. “I don't need a doctor. I think the heat, that smell, the whole thing combined. My brain just needed a break, I guess.”

A sickly drone echoed from above. Something heavy careening from above. Falling. A plunging aircraft. A hundred and fifty heads turned skyward, horrified to see a passenger jet, a big one, coasting over the park grounds. Seeing the big craft drift, they could tell it was not going to fall on them, but instead somewhere towards the horizon. The plane passed over the field, leaving the sky in a hurry. Its shadow swept out into the vineyard. Transfixed, the gathered watched as the airliner sunk lower until it met the

horizon with a concussive crash. Terror-stricken cries rang out when an orange fireball burst in the distance.

“Oh my God!” Screamed one of the guests. Little Lyle and Brook held hands as they cried.

Something brushed Jeff's shoulder, he turned and saw two of his groomsmen, Chris and Jeremy followed by Jeremy's girlfriend, Lara, all sprinting out into the field in the direction of crash. “Where are you going?” Jeff shouted to them.

“There might be survivors!” Chris hollered over his shoulder, sprinting into the vineyard.

THE TRAVERS FAMILY

THE TRAVERS COMPOUND

26 MILES SOUTH OF MOUNTED PLACE, MONTANA

11:05 AM LOCAL TIME

Glen met the Bronco at the end of the Travers 2-mile long dirt driveway. Grease across his forehead, wrench in hand. The thin lane opened to a wide patch of gravel in front of their shipping container compound. Containers stacked three-high in triangle formation, garden and rainwater capture in the middle. A brown barn sat 50 feet adjacent, a steel watchtower 30-feet high next to that, weather vane on top. Trees had been cut back three miles. Stone walls topped with razor wire ringed the 4200-acre property. Glen spent \$3.5 million digging a moat. They found the land for sale on the internet when they lived in Wyoming after they won the lottery.

Glen's son, Morris, walked from the compound, clipboard at his side. "Didn't think she'd be home already," Morris said.

"Inventory done?" Glen said.

Morris put his head down, didn't answer.

"That's what I thought," Glen said. "Where's your sister?"

"Reading, I think."

Georgia rolled the Bronco over toward the front of the barn, parked it in between a 1950s pickup and a backhoe. Glen looked at his son.

"Hen's need tending to," he said, "go get her."

Morris trudged away. Georgia stepped out of the truck. "Where's Jinny?" Glen asked.

"She's ready," Georgia said, "udder's fine. Didn't think I should bring in her in this. Maybe with your pickup."

"That's fine," Glen said. "You put the bridge up?"

"Of course."

"Let's see these packets."

Georgia walked around to the passenger side with Glen in tow. He opened the box to have a look, shook his head. He sighed. "We'll use 'em anyhow."

"Figured-" Georgia was caught mid-sentence, snapped her head to the side in reaction to a disgusting odor.

Glen turned up his nose and looked to the sky. He blew out a long breath, squinted and grit his teeth as he struggled to take in a new breath. Georgia coughed with her hands on her knees. Glen's mind raced. Gas. Couldn't figure where it was coming from. He saw Morris and his daughter, Fran, running toward them. Glen held up his hand, fought against the choking sensation to yell at his son. "Grab the walkie!"

Morris turned back for their home. Fran reached her mother, fear in her eyes. Georgia put an arm around her. "My nose is burning," Fran said.

"We've got to get inside to the masks."

"Is this it?" Georgia said.

Morris ran back into view holding two-way radios in both hands, snot running from his nose. "They're both dead!" He hollered.

Glen's expression changed. His eyes narrowed, his lips formed a thin straight line. "Yes," Glen said, hacking a wad of spit to the dirt. "This is it."

INGRID & URSULA ODENSHAW

HARPA CONFERENCE CENTER

REYKJAVIK, ICELAND

5:05 PM LOCAL TIME

The event host, Mika Sturm, smiled speaking the First Lady's name. Ingrid rose from her seat. The heat of every eye on her. Warm applause. She thanked Mika and took her place behind the podium, cue cards set in front of her. Much of the assembled were in obscured by the stage lights. Ingrid squinted but caught sight of her daughter flanked by Secret Service at the front of the room, in the corner. Seeing Ursula calmed her.

“Thank you,” Ingrid said into the microphone, hearing her voice carry through the vast black cavern. “Before I begin, I would just like to acknowledge the efforts-”

Gasps as the room fell dark. Urgent whispers and chatter filled the void where the hum of electronic devices had once been. No one could raise the screen on their phones. Coughing and sneezing took hold, a few cries. Ingrid's lungs burned and her face felt cold with the sudden disappearance of the lights. A commotion erupted in the distance, at the back of the hall. The other speakers remained in their chairs on stage, struggling to breathe. An organizer screamed. Watering eyes adjusted to the gray dimness, some small bit of daylight illuminated things just enough to see where you were going. Ingrid snapped a look left, only enough time to see Ursula no longer in her chair before Secret Service agents swarmed her, sweeping her from stage.

“Where is Ursula?” Ingrid said. “Where's my daughter?”

“She's safe, Mrs. Odenshaw,” she heard one of the agents say. “We're taking you to her now.”

“What's happening?”

None of the agents answered, they just kept moving. Ingrid's feet barely touched the floor.

WES POLLARD

RAWLIE'S SEAFOOD, 123 WATER STREET
NEW YORK CITY, NEW YORK
1:05 PM LOCAL TIME

Wes decided not to finish his lobster sandwich. The bread was dry. He sipped from his pint glass while waiting for the bill. TV screens over the bar filled with tickers featured talking heads he could barely hear over the lunch rush. Pete Klein and the rest of the traders on his floor at Rose Atlantic were upstairs on the roof patio. Wes wanted to get back to the office. Gold was making a move.

A pretty blonde got closer to him than she meant to, handing him his bill, holding a card reader. Patrons squeezed by them, there wasn't much room to walk.

"Sorry," she said, her cheeks went rosy.

"It's fine." Wes wasn't about to complain. He had his wallet out, reached for his Visa when TV screens snapped to black, the lights went out and a collective holler echoed from the back of the restaurant.

The young server looked at Wes with confusion on her face, but then anguish as a horrid odor spread throughout the room. A hundred people choking. Wes rubbed his eyes, the corners of his mouth stinging. Patrons flooded the exits sneezing gobs of snot and saliva as they went. Wes held out the card reader to the girl, she took it in hand.

"I've got no cash!" Is all Wes could get out between coughs. The young server disappeared into the throng. Customers flowed in a stream down the stairs from the rooftop patio, out into the street. As the restaurant emptied Wes could see through the windows Water Street was full of people. Stranger than that, Lower Manhattan had become quieter. People coughed and sneezed and choked and cried, but the constant symphony of vehicle engines, sirens and horns had stopped. Wes made his way out into the open air with no relief from the terrible smell. He rubbed his eyes again and stepped aside the torrent of humanity rushing down Water Street like lemmings. He was stunned to see the street plugged with vehicles. Not one engine ran. Not one horn honked. In every restaurant, in every business, every brokerage, it was the same. People hurried out of buildings into the

street. In the distance he saw a uniformed NYPD officer confronted by two hysterical men in suits.

A nervousness gripped Wes's gut. Unsure whether to follow the crowd or to struggle his way back up to his office. He pulled out his phone and couldn't get it to turn on. No one could. The pain behind his eyes became milder. An ache around his armpits dulled. Yet the sense of foreboding grew deeper. As much as he tried to think positive, images, memories from that morning in 2001 flashed in front of him. A hand landed on his shoulder. He swung right, relieved to see Pete Klein's face.

"You alright?"

"Yeah. What the hell is this?"

The two men stepped out of the on-rush of people, in between the back of one yellow cab and the front bumper of another.

"Wish I knew," Pete said. "Your phone working?"

"No."

"Everyone's headed to the bridge."

"Why Brooklyn?"

"Safer than here."

"Maybe."

"Do you think it's like this everywhere?"

Pete looked around. The mad dash thousands of people were making, like a massive sporting event or concert had just let out and everyone needed to catch the same train.

"I don't know," Pete said, "this is nuts."

A giant bang sounded from two blocks over. Steel meeting concrete with heavy impact. They couldn't see the source, but it left a ring in their ears. Screams from the distance. People instinctively dropped to their knees if only for a moment. It's happening again, was all Wes could think.

"Go!" Pete yelled to Wes, and they joined the crowd rushing for the Brooklyn Bridge. "Just go!"

DARLA STARR

5TH AVENUE
SEATTLE, WASHINGTON
10:05 AM LOCAL TIME

The audience was mostly men. They made the strangest faces, Darla thought. Some of them chose to show other things on their webcams instead of their faces while they watched her, while they fantasized about being with her. Darla had grown used to seeing it. She preferred her female customers, they never appeared as creepy. Darla never trusted men anyway, not since childhood.

One live stream had ended and she had begun another. Voyeurs linked to the feed from around the world. Darla could see a small sampling represented by small squares along the right side of her screen. Customers in various stages of self-pleasure ranging in locales from Singapore to Moscow to Qatar. Naked, her porcelain skin glowing in the morning light, Darla ran her fingers along the inside of her thigh. She let out a soft moan and tossed her head back, her black hair cascading across the white duvet. The cameras murmured as the autofocus on each buzzed to keep the center of the action clear. Darla only used her fingers in the beginning. She made sure to place herself in front of the cameras in such a way to give her viewers every detail, everything they wanted to see.

The buzzing ceased. The laptop died along with the stream. Darla could no longer hear her fridge running quietly in the background nor water through the pipes in the wall and a nasty aroma had filled her condo.

She cursed and she coughed and her skin felt like it was being pricked by thorns. A terrible acid burned at her crotch. She groaned, jumping from her bed, alarmed by the drool uncontrollably flowing out of her mouth. Darla pulled on white boxers and a tank top. The stinging on her body caused her to seek relief. She ran to the sink in her bathroom. Water came out in a slight trickle that dwindled to a drip. Then it dawned on her the power was out. It was the first time she'd experienced an outage in her new building. Management would hear about it. Coughing up phlegm, she spit it into the sink and jogged back into her bedroom to grab her cell. Before she picked it up she thought about the interrupted live stream and worried how many members she could lose over this inconvenience. Angered by the notion,

Darla pressed the button beneath her phone's screen. Nothing. Again she pushed it. Five times she pressed it, hard. Her phone would not respond.

"Come on."

Darla looked out over the city. Dozens of ants, more than usual were out on the street. Not one vehicle appeared to be moving, including a city bus. She slid open one of her windows expecting to hear horns, but she did not. Then, to her south, horror. Maybe five blocks away, a helicopter, black with a red insignia plunged from the sky. The craft hit the roof corner of a high rise. Darla's eyes widened watching it ricochet off the building top then falling far to the street below, out of her view.

"Oh my God."

She could hear the echo of the impact, the faint screams of people many floors below. Darla ran to her door and took a step out into the hall. Three other building residents stood dumbfounded. A middle-aged man from two doors down looked at Darla as she'd entered the corridor. He had wanted to speak, but then was compelled to lower his head facing the floor as though someone had sprayed mace into his eyes. Darla twisted her face as the burning in her nostrils trailed down into her throat. The smell was stronger than ever. A woman came out into the hall and saw the middle-aged man doubled over.

"Are you okay?" The woman said to the man. The man did not answer, he groaned and kept rubbing his eyes. He spit up a little on the carpet. The woman turned and looked at Darla, before she spoke she let out a little belch. "I tried to call 9-1-1. Nothing's working."

"I know," Darla said.

"Did you see the helicopter?"

Darla didn't want to engage in conversation, she just wanted relief.

"Hello?"

Ignoring the woman, Darla pushed her condo door with her bare foot and went back inside and engaged the secondary lock. Just in case. A feeling of vulnerability washed over her and she went to her bed. Darla put her lifeless laptop on the floor along with her toys. The acidic aches and the skin pricks became more mild, but the smell, she couldn't take it. Darla pulled the duvet to her face and tried to breathe through the thick material. Her breath became hot and labored and the wider she opened her mouth to draw in bigger breaths the more she worried she was causing herself to

hyperventilate. What if help could not come? That helicopter? What happened?

Relax, she told herself, drawing her knees up. She laid on her side looking out at the tops of buildings and the sunny sky. Thoughts of disgruntled customers pushed farther and farther from her mind. She hoped power would be restored soon. She tried not to think about the helicopter falling, smashing into that building.

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THE HOLDEMAN FAMILY

HIGHWAY 598

15 km EAST OF ROCKY MOUNTAIN HOUSE, ALBERTA

11:05 AM LOCAL TIME

Bryan wandered over to Terry's car. The constable was seated behind the wheel, his engine idling. He watched the firefighters blast the barn fire with powerful ropes of white water.

"I'm taking off, brother," Bryan said, raising his voice to be heard over the fire tanker's engines. "I'll talk to ya."

"Drive safe," Terry said, "give Cassie my best."

"You bet."

Bryan looked back over his shoulder at the thick yellow-gray smoke stubbornly rising above the water jets. No sooner had he turned to face his cruiser when the roar from the tanker truck's engine cut out, the water dropped and the hoses fell limp in the fighters' hands. Terry's car died too. The men across the road shouted to one another, and two of them clambered onto the tanker to restart it.

Bryan frowned. Curious, he thought. Then the noxious aroma hit him. It hit everyone. He swallowed hard and something attacked his airway. He coughed and snot bubbled from his nose. Bryan took the pain for a moment, trying to get his bearings. Through his watery eyes he saw Terry exit his vehicle, walking toward him.

"Tear gas," Bryan bellowed. Terry nodded in agreement. Both men went to the trunks of their respective cars and retrieved gas masks. Once they'd each purged and gotten a clean seal, they looked across the road to see the firefighters had beaten them to it. All were wearing their masks working like mad to get their trucks working again.

"You alright, brother?" Terry said.

Bryan gave him the thumbs up.

"What the hell was in that barn?" The constable laughed in response to his own question.

The two officers walked to the Fire Chief, Doug Reardon. The men shouted at one another to be heard through the masks.

"Trouble with the trucks, Chief?" Terry said.

“All died at once,” Doug said, “don't know what's going on. Dealing with a chemical fire though. You'll want to close off this road.”

“I'll call it in,” Bryan said.

“Good luck with that,” Doug said, “radios on ours aren't working.”

“They don't run off the engines.”

“Nope. Don't seem to matter though.”

Bryan jogged back across the highway. He got behind the wheel of his cruiser and keyed the CB radio. No response, no static, nothing. His cellphone was also dead and sure enough he couldn't start his vehicle. His eyebrows pushed down over his upper eyelids. His cop's sixth sense worked overdrive. What in the hell is this? He got out and went back to the others.

“You're right,” Bryan said. “No radio. No cell. Car won't start.”

The three men looked at each other trying to make sense of the situation. Meanwhile the fire started picking up again, orange flames rose higher inside the blackened structure. Chief Reardon's men kept trying to start the trucks to no avail. Reardon looked at the police officers squinting as though in deep thought, lips pursed. Maybe this wasn't just a chemical fire. That was the thought creeping through the Chief's brain.

“You know what this could be, right?” The Chief said.

Terry folded his arms and noted the stinging from his armpits had lessened in intensity. He looked at Doug and shook his head, understanding where the man was going with his thought. “What, a damned EMP?” Terry said. “I don't think so.”

“Let's not get carried away here,” Bryan said. “Probably dealing with something nasty that was in that barn.”

“That knocked out our engines?” Doug said. “Knocked out the radios? The phones? Show me a chemical that can do that.”

Bryan looked at Constable Allen. The two men recognized worry on the other's face. Neither wanted to admit to themselves that such a thing was even possible outside of the movies or on websites devoted to conspiracy theories. Bryan turned back to the Fire Chief. “Let's not jump to any conclusions yet,” he said. “First things first, let's double-check make sure everyone here, all of your crew, that everyone's alright. Same for us. Then we'll worry about securing the scene.”

“I think we're all fine, but how you going to secure the scene when you can't even move your vehicle? Can't even radio for help?” Doug said.

“Let's check on your men, make sure everyone's feeling alright. One step at a time,” Bryan said. “We'll worry about the rest after.”

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HELENA HILLEN

PAWEO PALMS ASSISTED LIVING FACILITY
KAUMAKANI, HAWAII
7:05 AM LOCAL TIME

He knows that which I don't know. Helena repeated the sentence three times staring up at the silver horse head on the shelf above her bed. He sees what I see. What I cannot see. The silver stallion gives me strength. Carries me to see my children.

Outside her window she could hear a commotion.

It had taken nearly an hour for a tow truck to arrive. Nancy stood holding onto Libby who held onto her puppy, Rico. Two Palms security guards waited nearby. The tow truck driver attached the booster cables to the battery in Nancy's car. She had left the headlights on overnight. Security staff, under Max Tremell's orders, told her to take a taxi home. Nancy refused. The guards decided calling someone in to get her car started was better than calling the police.

Max was not pleased. The assistant director walked out to the lot where the guards were standing. "What's taking so long?"

"He just got here," one of the guards responded.

The tow truck driver spoke loud so Nancy could hear him over his engine. "Get in and try it now."

Nancy nodded, then she looked at her little girl. "You stay right here. Got it? I'm just going to the car for a minute. Right over there. Okay?" The little girl smiled and Nancy walked to her vehicle.

The tow truck fell silent. An ugly scent took hold. No one could take in enough air. Pain erupted behind the eyes and inside their noses. Max Tremell dropped his clipboard and grabbed his knees spitting up with a sharp cough.

"Mommy," Libby cried. She drew in shallow breaths, her puppy blinked over and over shaking his head, wiping his snout with his tiny paw.

Nancy went to her daughter and pulled her close. She sneezed four times in quick succession. The tow truck driver ran around and jumped in behind the wheel of his rig. His armpits and the back of his neck were on fire. He tried to start up his truck, but it would not turn over.

Max spun around to his guards who were having trouble breathing themselves. "Check the rooms," he said, "I don't see the backup lights."

"Power's out," sputtered one of guards.

"If the generator's out too, that's a problem. Go."

The guards ran inside, but could not escape the odor. They agreed to split up. The one taking the East Wing noticed two residents laying in the long corridor. No pulse for either one. Max waited to hear a status report on his radio. He knocked the thing with his hand failing to get a signal.

"Call it in right away!" The guard shouted to his compatriot. "Code Red East Wing, times two! My radio's out!" His shouts were loud enough that they echoed through one of the resident's windows to the parking lot.

The guard looked in on Walter Johnson. Walter's machines had stopped and the elderly man gargled drawing in a thin, weak breath.

Nancy looked at Max after hearing the guard's words. She frowned at the assistant director, "what's code red?" She asked.

"It's nothing for you to worry about."

Their breathing became easier and the stinging sensation softened. Max glared at the tow truck driver. "What's the issue?"

"Won't start," the driver said.

"Well, hurry up and fix it."

"What does code red mean?" Nancy repeated.

"Mind your own business," Max said, "we have a lot going on right now."

East Wing, Nancy muttered to herself. "Dad!" She shouted. Holding Libby's hand she rushed from the lot toward the front door of the facility. Max attempted to step in her way.

"Where do you think you're going?"

"Out of my way."

She shoved the little man and he did not fight back. Nancy rushed, with Libby and Rico in tow, down the corridor to her father's room.

"Dad," she went to him and saw he was labored in his breathing. "Oh no." She saw the tubes attached to him, looking back and forth, unsure how to help. "Libby," she said, "go sit over there."

"But Mommy, what about-?"

"Just do it, Libby, okay?"

The little girl sensed the distress in her mother's tone. She carried Rico to the chair along the wall and sat.

Nancy put her ear close to her father's mouth, listening as a sip of air passed through. She looked out toward the hallway. "Can somebody help me? I need help in here!"

Most of the nursing staff had yet to report for the day. No one responded to Nancy's cry. Emergencies were playing out in every room.

Meanwhile, down the hall, one of the guards entered Helena's unit. Helena could see a shadowy figure enter. She had nearly choked on her own saliva but was happy the breathing had become easier. She detected a faint odor of sulfur.

"Ms. Hillen?" The guard called to her as he approached her bed. "Are you alright?"

He will see me through, Helena told herself. He gives me strength. He knows that which I don't know.

"Ms. Hillen?" The guard, as he had accidentally done a few times before, knocked his head on the shelf over Helena's bed. This time the knock jarred the solid silver paperweight from the edge of the surface. Before he could react the reflective horse head plummeted, striking Helena flush on her forehead like a cantaloupe thrown against a wall. The guard's eyes widened. He gazed at the old woman laying still in her bed. Unconscious. Blood trailed from the corners of her eyes.

The guard held his palm to his face. What the hell did I just do? I killed her! He tried his radio again, but it was dead.

He knows that which I don't know. He watches over me.

Helena's eyes flashed open. Her left arm thrust outward, the security guard standing over her sailed off his feet, back first through the large window out to the parking lot. He smashed off the back of a compact car and slumped to the ground covered in glass shards. The tow truck driver couldn't believe his eyes. He sat in his truck staring at the guard's lifeless body.

He watches over me.

Helena levitated from her bed and onto her bare feet. With a flick of the fingers on her right hand the silver stallion bust floated back up to its place on the shelf.

He sees what I see.

The elderly woman glided out to the corridor. She could hear Nancy crying and Libby's little puppy barking in another room. Helena moved in

their direction. Max and the other security guard appeared at the far end of the hall.

“Ms. Hillen,” Max yelled to her. “Please stay in your room. We're looking after this, alright?”

She ignored him.

“What is happening?” Max said to his guard. “She hasn't been on her feet in weeks. She couldn't walk.”

“I don't know what's happening, sir.”

“Put her back to bed, would you?”

“Ms. Hillen, we're going to help you, okay?”

“Can somebody help me, please?” Nancy screamed from her father's room. “My father cannot breathe!”

“We'll be right there, Mrs. Edina,” Max said. Then he pointed again at Helena. “Put her to bed. Now.”

The guard began jogging down the hall.

He sees what I see.

Helena shoved her hands in front of her. The guard slammed backward with lightning speed onto the floor, striking his head. He curled up in the fetal position holding his head, barely conscious. Max, dumbstruck, tried to take a step but Helena swept her hand in a flowing motion and she pinned the assistant director flat against the ceiling. He tried to scream, but could feel his windpipe constricted.

The old woman had a slight smile on her face. Good. She rose to the tips of her toes and floated down the hall toward Walter Johnson's room eager to see Nancy and Libby again.

He knows that which I don't know, she thought.

Carries me to see my children.

DEREK TANEV, JON ADDIS, & FREDDY WALSH

MCKINLEY AVENUE, VENICE
LOS ANGELES, CALIFORNIA
10:05 AM LOCAL TIME

Freddy grabbed the last two saltines from a plastic sleeve while Derek and Jon munched on what was left of theirs. Derek squinted as he washed down the dry crumbs with a bit of lukewarm water from the kitchen tap.

"These are stale as hell," Freddy said.

"Yeah, I know," Derek said, "it's all I could find in the cupboard."

"We gotta go out and find something," Jon said, trying hard to swallow the last few bites of cracker. "This isn't cutting it."

"I'm not going anywhere," Derek said, and he flopped down onto a burgundy couch missing its legs. He flung his right leg over the end of the couch and looked at the sun breaking through a bank of clouds outside the glass sliding doors that led to the backyard. "This is my spot for the day."

"You're pathetic," Jon said.

"Anyone seen my phone?" Freddy scanned the counter tops in the kitchen.

Derek pointed towards the corridor that led to the foyer near the front door. "Last I saw it, it was on the floor that way."

A putrid rotten egg smell suddenly grabbed at Derek's nose and he brought his palm to his face. "Gross," he said. "Jonny, was that you?"

The other two reacted in similar fashion. "Jesus," Jon said, "that's awful. That's not me, man."

"Me neither."

"What the hell is that?"

"Sewage or something?" Derek said, and he sat up straight on the sofa.

Freddy found his phone laying on the floor. He picked it up and touched the button on the side, but the screen would not light up. "Stupid thing."

"What?"

"My phone," Freddy said. "It won't turn on."

"Battery's probably dead, dumbass," Jon said.

Derek then pointed to the digital clock on the stove. The screen was blank. "Look," he said. "Power's out."

"Great."

“You think it's just us?” Freddy said. “Like the house's wires and the pipes and all that are screwed up? Or is it the city?”

“How should I know?”

Then a loud beep emitted from the ceiling. The smoke alarm kicked back on and the stove clock began flashing 12:00.

“Power's back.”

“Weird. I guess it was just a flicker.”

“You think this smell has anything to do with it?”

“Freddy, you keep asking all these questions,” Jon said, “like we're god-damned scientists or something. How are we supposed to know?”

“Sorry, geez.”

“One thing I do know is I'm hungry,” Jon said, and he grabbed his jacket. “I'm going to Lacey's work. She can buy us something. You coming?”

WARREN BOYD

TWO-MILE CORRECTIONAL FACILITY
SOUTH OF BELLE GLADE, FLORIDA
1:05 PM LOCAL TIME

Warren dropped the book to his chest feeling a scraping sensation across his scalp and a burning in his eyes. He scrunched up his nose opting for a shallow breath not wanting a full dose of the awful odor. He could hear some kind of commotion echoing down the corridor towards his cell and it caused him to sit up on his mattress. Some frantic voices. Orders being given. Finally, a break from the boredom, Warren thought.

He stood up from his cot and walked to the cell door. Even at the most extreme angle he could never get a glimpse through the window slit of the guard's office at the other end of the corridor. The best he could do on a sunny day was to catch shadows or slight reflections in the concrete of activity down that way. He saw many shadows dancing around. More voices, yelling. Good, he thought. Maybe something will come of this day after all.

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ADELE MYJINSKI

ABOARD F/A-18C FIGHTER
OVER NEZ-PERCE-CLEARWATER NATIONAL FORESTS, IDAHO
10:05 AM LOCAL TIME

Someone back at Naval Air Station Sloan in Nevada was trying to communicate, but it came through in fits and starts through Adele's helmet.

"Sloan this is Magic, go again," she said into her mic while maneuvering her fighter jet in a circular pattern high above Idaho's vast wilderness. She'd never encountered any issue with the communications equipment in her helmet nor on board the plane. Again a male voice could be heard starting and stopping. It was choppy enough she couldn't make out a single word.

Then the F/A-18C's engines died. Her instrument panel went black. Adele didn't panic. She had a fighter pilot's countenance. Cold-blooded efficiency honed through rigorous training. When things were at their worst she had an innate ability to slow her pulse and grow calmer.

Dead stick, she thought. Huh. She ran through the diagnostics in her head. Odd.

Nothing came through her helmet, not even static.

The fighter jet plunged several hundred feet. Pulling significant Gs in the fall, Adele began cycling through her options. They appeared like full-color drop-down menus in her vision. Pages of protocol she'd committed to memory.

Just as she'd contemplated whether or not she might have to eject, the plane's systems all kicked back in at once. Gently nudging the stick in front of her, the jet responded. Pleased, Adele smiled a little and she regained altitude.

Who needs coffee? She joked to herself. Whatever had happened, the communications equipment seemed back on-line as well. A male voice snapped crisply through her helmet headset. "Magic, this is Sloan, over."

"Sloan, I'm here. Lost touch there for a minute."

"Yes, Lieutenant," said the controller. "Be advised, you are to return to base at once."

"Everything alright, Sloan?"

"An incident in New Mexico," the controller said, "the base is being evacuated, Commander Dominguez's orders."

“Evacuated?” Adele said, incredulity in her voice. “The entire base?”

“Affirmative.”

Must be some kind of incident, she thought.

The controller's voice returned. “You're on assignment,” he said.

Adele shook her head. She knew what that meant.

“I'm hours from my transfer.”

“Going to have to wait, Magic,” said the male voice. “You're needed for a special evacuation. Specific orders from the Commander himself.”

“Yeah, let me guess, I get to fly the bus full of base staff out of there.”

“Uh, not exactly.”

PHILIP & CHARLES STIRLING

ABOARD TIDINGS FISHING VESSEL

198 km SOUTHEAST OF LUNENBURG, NOVA SCOTIA

2:05 PM LOCAL TIME

The rigging had all been ripped away. The storm's fury had carried them a few kilometers farther from shore. Small puddles of salty water covered the deck, reflecting glints of sunlight into Philip's face. He laid still, blinking, amazed he was still alive. The boat floated on calm waters. The storm had blown through just as fast as it had rode up on them. The giant wave thrashed them around like socks in a spin cycle, but they were alive. *Tidings* was still in one piece, though the debris laying all over and the wrecked riggings and the torn lines as well as the missing dory would prove crippling to their business, for the time being anyway. Philip felt some tenderness in his ribs, but he could move all his extremities and he was grateful. He raised his head just as he saw his father at the other end of the vessel pick himself up off the deck.

Charles trudged towards his son, holding his left arm to his chest. "Y'all right, son?"

"I'm good. You hurt your arm?"

"Cracked it I think. Collarbone maybe. That was a helluva a ride."

"Yep. Boat's wrecked though."

Charles held out his right hand and pulled his son back to his feet. Philip pulled off his dry suit and felt some relief as the sky looked to be clearing and the water smoothed out like a pane of glass all around them.

"Insurance should cover most of it," Charles said. "I ain't too worried. So long as the engine goes. We'll be alright."

They both reacted to an awful smell that hit them both at once.

"What is that?"

Charles searched the horizon all around them. No sign of another vessel. He thought maybe a big tanker had dropped its load. A chemical spill?

"Some kind of gas?" Philip wondered.

"Could be." Charles coughed as he choked back a breath. "It ain't nice though, I'll tell ya."

Philip was happy to hear the CB radio crackle behind them. A female voice came through. "Charles, Phil, you there?"

"It's Deeanne," Philip said.

"Just glad the damned radio still works." Charles walked to the console and keyed up the mic. "Yeah, we're here Deeanne. Caught in a storm though. She's in a bad way I'm afraid."

"You alright?" Deeanne said.

"We are. We'll be headin' back in here right away once I see if she'll start."

"Keep me posted on that. And uh, just wanted to let you and Phil know, got a call from Labrador. Abe's been taken to hospital."

Abe was Philip's grandfather, Charles' father-in-law. Immediately, Philip could feel a burning sensation in the pit of his stomach.

"What happened?"

"Not too sure," Deeanne said. "Some boys hit him I guess, don't know much more than that."

Philip grew so angry upon hearing the words, he'd have flown to Labrador to find those boys himself if he could've.

"He alright though?" Charles said.

"Don't know," Deeanne said, "just tellin' ya all I know. He's in the hospital there. You boys comin' in now?"

"We are," Charles said.

"You got that smell out to wheres you are?" Deeanne said. "Some kind of thing happening around here. A gas leak or something."

"You've got it there?" Charles said. "Yeah, we can smell it all the way out here. What's going on back there?"

"I couldn't tell ya," Deeanne said. "Anyway. Get back soon as you can. I'll try to find out more about Abe. Nora's the one who told me by the way, so don't worry 'bout her, she already knows."

Charles's thoughts then turned to his wife, Nora. It was her dad. She'll be wanting to fly to Goose Bay, no doubt, he thought.

"Okay, thanks Deeanne. Out for now."

Charles turned to his son who was fighting back tears. He could see the boy had balled fists at his sides. "I know, son," he said. "You're mad. Yous is close, I get it. We'll get back and we'll go see him, alright?"

Philip glared at his father, resented him slightly because he knew Charles and Abe had clashed over the years. Still, he recognized his father was saying something that wouldn't have been comfortable for him even with Abe being in hospital. He knew Charles hated going to Labrador. He knew

traveling to Happy Valley-Goose Bay would've been the last thing he'd have wanted. The longer he thought about it, the cooler he became. He wiped the remnant of a tear from his eye and nodded at his dad.

“Okay, good,” Charles said. “Now let's go see about this motor.”

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TRENTON CHAMBERS

TUSCOLA PENITENTIARY

TWO MILES WEST OF TUSCOLA, TEXAS

12:05 PM LOCAL TIME

"I tell you, man," Hector said, turning his nose up at his tray, "this shit is disgusting."

Trenton downed the last of his not-quite-green peas that he'd attempted to coat with as much starchy gravy as he could to improve their flavor. "I've had better," he agreed. He slid his tray off to the side and rested his elbows on the cafeteria table.

The room was full of prisoners eating lunch while teams of guards looked on. Voices and laughter bounced off the high ceiling above. You could barely hear yourself think. Trenton was actually looking forward to the confines of his cell where he could throw himself back in the Hornblower novel he was reading.

An inmate, walking up the aisle carrying his empty tray towards the front, brushed Trenton's back. He turned and looked to see Trenton looking at him. "Watch yourself old man," the prisoner said.

Trenton frowned at him and then began to laugh. The much younger inmate didn't know what to make of the reaction and without another word turned and kept walking.

"He don't know who he playin' with," Hector said, chuckling. "Mister Golden Gloves over here."

"He's a kid," Trenton said.

"He's a punk."

"You know how it is, everybody's gotta front."

Hector went to take in a breath, and immediately a foul odor overtook him. "Damn, homie, what is that?"

Right away the cafeteria became an echo chamber of coughs and gagging sounds. Prisoners were doubled over. Guards held their noses. The overhead lights cut out and the room was bathed in red emergency lights as a loud buzzer sounded.

A few inmates shouted, but then a voice came over the loudspeaker, booming for all to hear. "Everybody down!" Said the powerful voice. "Down! Now!"

The guards grabbed their weapons and aggressively moved in a ring around the edge of the room. Trenton frowned as he looked up to see beams of daylight stream in near the ceiling. What in the hell is going on, he thought, and then he laid prone on the floor along with everybody else.

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MAGGIE STONE

HIGHWAY 201

1 km WEST OF BLOCKADE AT 200 JUNCTION, MANITOBA

12:05 PM LOCAL TIME

Maggie and Chester stood watching while a few of the locals banged drums in unison. A crowd of fifty others from the reserve stood nearby. Some were watching the drummers, some were watching the police who stood in a line a fair distance back. About twelve locals kept watch over a wooden barricade they'd sprawled across the highway adorned with a white cloth sign draped over with "PROTECT OUR WATER" written in black paint. The band's insignia was drawn just beneath it.

In the time since Maggie had arrived, a minivan carrying a camera crew and a reporter from Winnipeg had shown up and taken a position between the police line and the highway barricade.

Maggie and Chester both turned to look at the line of RCMP officers. Maggie glanced over at her pickup truck once again to make sure she could still see Rosie inside, relieved that she could. A few of the others had allowed their kids to run around the protest site, but she was reluctant to do the same.

Chester let out a sigh as he looked to his band chief, uncertainty in his eyes. "What are you thinking? Maybe we should release a statement?"

Maggie shrugged. "I think Darren and those guys just want to have something to say for a while, you know?"

"Yep."

"They can have their say. They're gonna be on camera here, on the news. I think it'll be enough and they'll stop for the day."

"That's what you hope. No arrests."

"I'm not putting anything past the cops," Maggie said with a bit of a laugh. "But, no, I think Darren and them wants to come out tomorrow and do it again, they can."

"Yep."

"Oh my god," Maggie said, her jaw dropped. "That smell."

Everyone seemed to react at once.

"That's terrible. Where's it coming from?"

Maggie held her hand to her face and she looked all around the horizon seeing nothing, but mostly open prairie. “No idea,” she said. “I gotta get out of this.” She scrambled over to her pickup and got in quickly. A lot of the others had the same idea, though most of the RCMP officers remained standing on the highway, even as they coughed and held their noses.

There was no reprieve in the truck and Maggie could see her little daughter with her face buried in the crook of her elbow. “Mom, it's bad.”

“I know,” Maggie said, feeling a slight stinging sensation on her lips. “It'll go away in a minute.”

KEITH OLDHAM

THE CAPITAL GARDEN PLAZA HOTEL
TORONTO, ONTARIO
1:05 PM LOCAL TIME

Keith sat outside the General Manager's office listening to the muffled sounds of an angry man venting coming from inside. The General Manager's secretary, Livia, looked at him from behind her desk with a sympathetic smile.

"Should just be a few more minutes," she said.

Keith did his best to give her a friendly smile in return. He was not looking forward to speaking with Mr. Silvoni, the GM. The man was friendly enough in the few exchanges he'd had with him, but he had a reputation for being a stickler, and he was an intimidating presence. He'd often walk the hotel property in silence, capable of reducing his staff to a puddle just from a stern look.

Needless to say, all of the shouting inside the office was coming from Mr. Miller whose car Keith had damaged and whose bikes he'd completely ruined. Mrs. Miller was also in the meeting, but Keith couldn't hear her at all. Mr. Miller sounded angry enough for them both.

Suddenly, the door to Mr. Silvoni's office swung open.

"You can go in now," Livia said.

Keith gulped and stood up. He walked in the door which was being held open by his immediate supervisor, Ben, who had also been in the meeting and had kept mostly silent. Ben's face appeared regretful as Keith walked past. Mr. Silvoni, intimidating as ever in his coal black designer suit stood behind his desk glaring at Keith as he walked in. He held out a hand indicating for Keith to sit on a small sofa along one wall while the others sat in large office chairs. Keith sank into the cushion and folded his hands into his lap. He could feel Mr. Miller's eyes penetrating through him and it caused him to concentrate his gaze on the floor.

"Well?" Mr. Miller said loudly. "Shall we go over this again?"

"Mr. Miller," the General Manager said, taking a seat behind his desk, "please."

"No," Mr. Miller said, "I want this guy's job."

His wife held her hand out. "Rob, calm down," she said.

“I will not. I want this guy fired. Do you know how much money he's cost me?”

“Mr. Miller,” Silvoni said, “of course we will take care of-”

“I don't care,” Mr. Miller said, “this is a service based company. This is a hotel. And not a cheap one either-”

The thick sulphur smell hit him mid-sentence. Everyone in the room stopped, taken aback by the intensity. Keith's armpits burned. Mr. Silvoni and Ben glanced at one another, both immediately thinking of what could be happening within the hotel to cause this.

CLARA TIERNEY

CENTRAL KALAHARI GAME RESERVE
26 MILES NORTH OF KIKAO, BOTSWANA
7:05 PM LOCAL TIME

Reluctant though she had been to stop filming the giraffes, Clara recognized the guide had made the right call. The sun was setting so they had lost a lot of their good light and not long after she'd returned to their Land Rover they encountered the rather large pride of lions reported to be in the area.

Clara and her crew were on the makeshift road, two wheel ruts separated by a strip of scrub grass, headed back for their encampment near town when the convoy's engines all died at once. A powerful odor struck at the same time.

There were five vehicles in a line, relatively close together. One of the other drivers climbed out of his Rover and ran to the second one in line carrying Clara.

"We are stuck," he said, his accent thick.

"I can see that," Clara responded. "What do you suppose is happening? That's sulphur I smell."

Both her own driver and the other man looked at her, puzzled.

"Sulphur," she repeated. "That smell." She waved her hand in front of her nose to indicate what she'd meant.

"Sulphur," the man standing outside the vehicle said it carefully, trying to emulate Clara's pronunciation.

"Right," she said, "gas, chemical, element. I don't know why we can smell that out here." She thought about the engines quitting all at once. They have to be related somehow, she figured.

"We have plenty of gas," her driver said. He tried the ignition again. No luck. He waved to the man outside his window. "Go back and try again to start," he said.

One of Clara's cameramen, Danny, appeared at her window from one of the other vehicles. "What the devil do you surmise is the cause of this?" He said. "All I can do to keep from losing my lunch over this mess."

"It is awful," Clara said. "I can't understand why the vehicles would all die at once."

“You've got me on that,” Danny said. “One thing's for certain, they'd better well be going soon. I'd hate to be out here after dark.”

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DENNIS KING

STONEWALL PARK
CHARLOTTE, NORTH CAROLINA
1:05 PM LOCAL TIME

The stadium was packed. A sell-out. Not bad for a game in the dog days of August for an expansion team way out of playoff contention. A lot of Philadelphia fans were among the crowd. A lot of fans wearing Dennis King jerseys. The sun was out, the sky was clear, and the humidity was relatively under control. Dennis stood in the on-deck circle for his team just beyond the edge of the visitor's dugout. He watched his teammate Omar Montoyo walk to the batter's box, the first batter of the game. The opposing pitcher threw his last warm up pitch and the umpire declared 'game on'.

Strike one. Montoyo watched the first pitch of the game sail past him, just catching the edge of the zone. The pitcher, Chris Charles, began his windup for the next pitch and stopped mid-motion which seemed to coincide with the loud gasp coming from the capacity crowd. Everyone made a face. Some fanned themselves with game programs trying to push the aroma away. The umpire held out his arms to call time out, and Charles walked off the mound a few steps blowing snot out of his nose.

Dennis stopped swinging the warm-up bat and took a knee in the on-deck circle gazing up at the crowd wondering why he could feel a bit of a burning sensation on the back of his arms and neck.

The public address announcer attempted to say something through the microphone in front of him and noted his whole system was dead. He pulled out his cell phone and noticed it too was not working. He turned to see his colleagues all had the same issue.

“Somebody get Oscar,” the announcer said, “we've clearly got a situation, and this could get ugly.”

MICHAEL JANVIER & ELIZA CHAMPION

AMETHYST CAY RESORT

TURKS AND CAICOS

1:05 PM LOCAL TIME

Michael napped while Eliza braved the paparazzi in the small town market place outside their exclusive resort. He didn't wake when the terrible odor hit, and so he didn't notice that his cell phone, practically another appendage to him, had stopped working.

Meanwhile, around the shops where Eliza had been accompanied by bodyguards, people were running in all directions, panicked by the sudden onset of the strong smell and the accompanying power outage. Eliza's security team encircled her and walked her back towards the golf carts they'd driven from the edge of the resort property.

Jesper, her head security guard tried to start each of the carts, no luck with either of them. "Looks like we'll have to walk back."

"No big deal," Eliza said, pressing her oversized sunglasses closer over her eyes. "Actually, wait," she said. "Let me call Michael. See if they've lost power there."

The guards stood vigilant while she pulled her phone from one of her bags. It did not turn on. "No service," she said, frowning at Jesper. "Is that normal in a power outage? Like these things run off battery, right?"

"That's right, ma'am."

"Okay, whatever," she said, groaning in frustration. "Let's just go back, I don't want to be out here in case this turns into something."

BOB ANGEL

HENDERSON CONVENTION CENTER
NEW ORLEANS, LOUISIANA
12:05 PM LOCAL TIME

Bob sat in a plastic chair in the security office located in the basement of the convention center cradling a paper cup with some water while the officer with the New Orleans Police Department seated across from him finished writing his notes. Two security guards stood watch outside the door while another two police officers sat inside the office along with the security manager.

“Alright, Mr. Angel,” the officer said looking up from his pad. “Did you want to add anything to your statement at this time?”

Bob's eyes were bloodshot, and the skin on his face looked like it'd been rubbed raw with sandpaper. He shook his head. “No,” he said quietly. “You have it all.”

“And you're planning to carry on with the convention, that correct?”

“Do you believe that I shouldn't?”

“That's not what I'm saying,” the officer said, “but obviously if you choose to stay in the building, we're going to have to figure something out. There might be others out there.”

“But you don't know that for certain.”

“No sir, we don't, but-” the officer stopped mid-sentence, punched in the face by a terrible smell. “Golly,” he muttered.

Everyone in the office reacted at once. The fluorescent lights in the ceiling cut out then too, and the computers in the room shut off. There was a loud click and the back-up emergency lights came on. A rumbling sounded over them, no doubt hundreds of people on the move on the floor of the convention center up above. The security manager tried his radio right away only to find it dead. He leaped from his seat and hollered at his people outside the door. “Code Black!” He shouted, and the two men dashed off.

A thought immediately occurred to Bob. He looked at the police officer across from him. “You have no radio service as well, correct?” He said.

The officers tried to use the radios attached to their uniforms, they were dead.

“Your cell phones as well, yes?” Bob said.

Sure enough, the officers each tried to engage their phones and again, no luck.

Bob nodded slightly, an acknowledgment of something he'd just realized. “Please excuse me,” he said to the others in the room, headed towards the door.

“Where are you going?” The officer with the notepad asked him. “I wouldn't advise you to go wandering off given you were threatened. Especially not now.”

“I'm not going far,” Bob said, “just outside the office for a minute. I need a breather.”

“Alright,” the officer relented.

Bob stepped out and rounded the office's exterior wall where he wouldn't be seen nor heard. He pulled his cell phone from his pocket, probably one of the only working phones in the world. His closest assistant, Joseph, had the other. Joseph picked up on the first ring. “I knew you'd be calling,” he said to his boss. “This is what we think it is?”

“Yes,” Bob answered. “I'm coming to you. Please make the arrangements.”

“Will do.”

DASH Q

INDEPENDENCE ARENA
KANSAS CITY, MISSOURI
12:05 PM LOCAL TIME

With a charming yet cocky smile, Dash deflected his interviewer's question about who he's been rumored to be dating. The magazine reporter had interviewed over a dozen big name celebrities, and she was adept at sliding personal questions in among those aimed more at the creative projects of her subjects, but Dash had been asked those types of questions in interviews so many times he'd adopted an effective means of dodging and deflecting. T.J. would joke with him that if his voice after gave out on him he'd have a great second career as a politician.

The magazine reporter, Stacy glanced down at her notes, looking to ask the superstar one more question before he would be taken back to the other end of the arena to his private area. While Stacy scanned the page, Dash looked to his assistant Kelsey with an expression that said 'can we be done now?'.

Kelsey leaned in to Stacy and said quietly, "I think we're good to wrap things up now."

Stacy looked up at Dash from her notes and smiled. Then her eyes expanded to twice their size as she was hit by the terrible aroma of rotten eggs. Dash twisted his face in disgust. The magazine photographer accompanying Stacy coughed loudly, and Kelsey downed the last of her water.

Kelsey looked at one of the arena security guards standing nearby. "Can we check on things?" She said. "Is there something going on with the building?"

The man rushed off to find out.

"Let's get you back," Kelsey said to Dash, and he slid off the wooden director's chair where he'd been parked for the interview.

Dash held his face in his hands as he and Kelsey and a security guard briskly exited the media room.

"It was nice meeting you," Stacy called after Dash through a pinched nose. He said nothing in return as he and the others hurried away.

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SUBJECT 736

DARPA FACILITY 88, "THE CLOVER"

1.5 MILES UNDERGROUND, 20 MILES SOUTHWEST OF
ATLANTA, GEORGIA

1:05 PM LOCAL TIME

"Are you seeing this," Tim said, checking one of the monitors from a whole bank of them along one wall.

Eric rolled his chair over to have a look and noticed three of their data feeds from servers up at the ground level offices within the facility had stopped suddenly, something neither of the men had ever witnessed in their entire time working at "The Clover".

"Weird," Eric said. "Let me call Andy."

Eric picked up one of the desk phones and waited for the call to ring through. One of the super-soldier project supervisors, Andy Swain, answered on the fifth ring sounding a bit out of breath. "Yeah?"

"Andy it's Eric."

"You guys are alright down there? You still have power?"

"Yes, of course. Why? What's going on?"

Andy let out a loud sigh. "Wish I could tell you." Eric could hear people shouting in the background. "We just had a major blackout. Lasted all of a minute, but it was enough to give us a heart attack is all. Even the generators were down. All of 'em."

"Whoa," Eric threw Tim a look of panic. "What the heck?"

"Yeah," Andy said, "we're still trying to figure it out, and there's this awful stench. No idea. Anyway, we're back up and running here, I think."

"You think?"

"Well, we don't know what's caused it. But, looks like the extra \$200 million they put into your guys' redundancies has paid off. I see on camera the big boy's still sleeping. And you said you didn't lose power, right?"

"Right," Eric said, "but, the servers on L-9 appear to be down."

"Yeah, I know, we're working on it. Shouldn't be too long, we've called everyone in."

"No idea what caused this?" Eric said.

"No idea," Andy confirmed, "a cyber attack maybe, but I'll tell ya, to effect anything at this facility this way it'd have to be state sponsored with a

lot of money behind it.”

“No kidding.”

“I'm just glad everything down there is still online. That's the main thing.”

“Yep,” Eric said, “I'd say we got lucky.”

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LIN CHOU

XIANGFENG DENIM FACTORY
SHANGHAI, CHINA
1:05 AM LOCAL TIME

Her eyes opened into complete darkness, not the dimly lit gray haze of night she normally experienced on sleepless nights inside the worker dorms. Lin closed her eyes and opened them again, and as she became more alert the smell caught her nostrils. She pulled the sheet over her nose and mouth and breathed in slow. She reached out and felt the concrete wall in front of her, then she turned over on her bunk and could see that outside there was no light at all other than the moon and stars. Strange.

A few voices whispered beneath her. The other young women woke to the horrid odor. One of the them was dismayed her cell phone had stopped charging along with all the others crowded around the one plug.

“The electricity is out,” one of the women said.

“Out in the street as well.”

“Go back to sleep,” one of them said. “The workers will fix things.”

Lin could feel her heavy eyes beckoning her to sleep once more. Then the thought occurred to her. Maybe without power the factory doors couldn't stay locked.

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LISA JACKSON & GARRETT TIGNISH

BUCHANAN NUCLEAR GENERATING STATION

BUCHANAN, NEW YORK

1:05 PM LOCAL TIME

The workers had planted Lisa and Garrett in one of the small, windowless lunch rooms almost since they'd arrived. Lisa called her editor at one point and told him, "they're stonewalling us. No one's coming to get us, show us around, I can just tell."

As an hour ticked by, Lisa settled into the orange plastic chair next to the lunch room table, convinced she and Garrett were dead in the water. They wouldn't stick you in here and make you wait this long if they were going to cooperate, she thought.

Garrett stood making a coffee at the counter. Make the best of a bad situation was how he saw it, but coffee wasn't going to make up for a possible loss of a story of this magnitude in Lisa's mind. The cheap coffee maker sputtered as it poured java into an oversized mug Garrett had seized from the cupboard. He reached towards the shelf above him for the box of sugar cubes when the room fell dark and a deep groaning sound rattled through the floor beneath them. Without windows, the lunch room was completely pitch black.

"Oh my god," Lisa said, "can you smell that?"

"Rancid," Garrett said.

They didn't move for about twenty seconds and they listened as outside the room people were hollering and they could hear footsteps running in different directions.

"A power outage," Lisa said, incredulous, "you've got to be kidding me."

"Something's gone wrong."

"What do you mean?"

"We should have some lights on by now. The generators at this place would've kicked in pretty fast. You know what a place like this would turn into without power."

Lisa contemplated his words and tried not to entertain that spark of fear that had just entered her stomach. "Maybe the generators aren't hooked into this lunch room."

“I doubt that's the case,” Garrett said. “This entire facility would have more than one fail-safe. The fact that we're still in pitch darkness a full minute later tells ya something.”

“Are you trying to scare me, Garrett? Because you're doing a good job.”

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